Too Damn Hot For You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36983728.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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Summary

Firehouse 309 is unusual for a lot of reasons, but they add up to mean that Adora and Catra couldn't have asked for a better station to work at. The firehouse is family, and though that closeness once threatened to tear their friendship apart, it managed to heal it again once Catra joined as a volunteer firefighter. Of Adora looks with a little too much admiration at Catra whenever she pulls off a daring rescue, no one seems to have noticed yet.
(Firefighter Catradora AU)

The Firehouse Cat

Chapter Notes

> This AU occurred to me when I was looking the LEGO website and saw the (now retired, I believe, that's how old this idea is) Fire Brigade set. Because I'm a parody of myself. I've been sitting on this idea since July but it's finally time for the Yearning to commence.
> This AU is a bit different in that it isn't so much an overarching narrative/continuous timeline but rather a series of vignettes set in this universe that are in roughly chronological order. Each chapter is kind of a one shot of this firehouse AU.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Adora! Get your ass down here!" Glimmer shouts from the vehicle bay. Adora hears her, she's just *stuck*.

"I need Catra!" she turns her head to call back. When she looks at her locker again, Melog is still curled up in her helmet, his tail flicking lazily and his eyes narrow slits as he regards Adora. His expression is an unbothered challenge: *do you dare attempt to touch me?* The answer, even for Adora, is no. Ever since Catra pulled him out of a fire as a kitten, he has known no master but her. He lets Adora pet him, he even comes wandering up to her for it, but if Melog doesn't initiate a touch then he won't tolerate it from anyone except Catra. Adora isn't Catra and she wants to keep her hand.

"She took the first truck already! Stop being a baby, we need to go!" Glimmer calls back. *Great*. Adora really can't afford to waste any more time. She's at least mostly dressed in her uniform. Everyone but Catra waits until they're fully kitted out before thinking of moving Melog against his will, but Melog is laying on the rest of her gear. They just got a call and have to go though. Adora grits her teeth,

bracing herself to be swatted at, and darts down to reach for her helmet.

It turns out to be a smart play. Melog's eyes widen and he watches her with interest as she lifts the helmet, but he doesn't swat at her. After all, *technically* she didn't move him, just the thing he is curled up in. That kind of transgression wouldn't have flown when he was a kitten, but he allows her to do it now. Adora quickly gathers her other things and slams her locker shut, hurrying down to where everyone else is already climbed aboard the second firetruck. Entrapta coos from the driver's seat when she sees Adora hurrying in with Melog, still inside her helmet and tucked under one arm.

"Coward!" Glimmer calls as Adora climbs up the steps, but her tone is teasing. Glimmer would have grabbed a spare helmet instead probably. Adora rolls her eyes as she lifts her helmet up to the dash. Melog dutifully hops out of the helmet to curl up against the windshield and get in Entrapta's way instead. Normally Adora is his favorite target – probably because he is the most tolerant of her – but Melog loves the fire engines. Darla is his favorite, and Darla is *Entrapta's* favorite, so he spends a lot of time with her as well.

"Angella would have my ass if we needed to replace more equipment," Adora huffs back at Glimmer as she takes up her actual spot on the engine. She is far more worried about pissing off the chief than annoying Melog. He has been the firehouse cat for months now, he needs to get used to getting out of the way sometimes. At least he's well-behaved when he's in the truck. He will keep himself up on the dash or find somewhere else to tuck into. He won't try to get out when they arrive unless Catra comes by to collect him.

"Please, she loves him. If you told her that he broke it, she wouldn't say anything," Glimmer returns. Adora snorts. Yeah, that's the thing: Melog likes Angella for *no reason*. She is the only person other than Catra who is allowed to boss him around. She can't carry him under her arm like a basketball like Catra can, but if she orders him out of her office, he'll leave. Adora could beg and plead Melog to move but

Melog – and Catra – would just find it amusing. Adora is confident that Melog likes her second best, but he doesnt listen to her .

He really is Catra's shadow.

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The call turns out to be a kitchen fire that is already out by the time they arrive and they sent two firetrucks out for nothing. Catra comes to collect Melog from Adora before both the engines drive back. She laughs in Adora's face when Adora tells her what he did with the helmet and, as if to rub it in her face, she tucks him inside her shirt and zips it up around him. Adora can hear him purring. She does her best not to pout and fails. She isnt even sure which one of them she is more jealous of.

Adora would like to ride back on Catra's engine, but they arent sticking around long enough to shuffle people around, so she reluctantly rides back with Entrapta. When they reach the firehouse, driving past the nine-stripe pride flag they fly out front to much controversy, Adora finds that Melog is still zipped inside Catra's uniform. She cant help but glare a little as they walk to put away their gear. Catra notices, laughing and reaching up to scratch his ears.

"You could *try* instead of just assuming that hell take your arm off, you know," Catra tells her . Adora raises a brow at her as Glimmer outright laughs behind her. Everyone tries to pet Melog at least once a week. He has progressed from swatting at them to merely ducking away from their touch, but he's as temperamental as his mistress. He only allows interactions that he begins.

"He doesnt like the rest of us like he loves you," Adora replies, turning away to strip out of her gear. Catra doesnt reply - what is

there to say, Adora is *right* – but the others begin snickering behind them. Adora turns around with a sense of trepidation and finds Catra grinning as she holds Melog out to her. Adora finds the cat shoved in her arms – her *bare arms*, without any equipment to protect her – before she can even protest.

She scrambles to get her arms in some kind of position that Melog will find acceptable. Everyone laughs at her as she tries to juggle a cat. To her shock, Melog doesn't start growling. His claws don't even come out. After a few seconds, Adora ends up with Melog cradled in her arms like a baby. The tip of his tail twitches and he blinks up at her slowly, apparently unbothered.

Catra is laughing at her dumbstruck expression now too.

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Sometimes, Melog comes home with Catra, and thus Adora by extension. Melog is, indisputably , the firehouse cat, but he is also *Catra's* cat, and Catra is only a volunteer firefighter rather than full-time like Adora. Catra is definitely going to be the next full-time hire, but for now her actual job is at the mechanic shop fifteen minutes away from their apartment. Sometimes Melog refuses to be at the firehouse without her, though, and he follows them when they go to leave. Angella often schedules Adora and Catra to work at the same time, but despite Adora working on her own today, Melog still tries to hop in her car when she leaves, apparently missing Catra.

Adora lets him, shooting off a quick text to the firehouse group chat so they know that he isn't missing. She' s a little worried he would try to walk to their apartment if she doesn't bring him herself, and though his shiny blue collar would keep him from getting picked up by animal control, cars are still a threat. Melog dutifully jumps out of the car when they arrive and follows Adora up to the door of their

shared apartment. t' s a little shitty, but it's way nicer than what either of them would be able to afford on their own and Melog doesnt hesitate to make himself at home as usual.

Catra is working a shift down at the Fright Zone – alright, it' s an Auto Zone, but with how draconian her boss is the nickname is appropriate – so she wont be back for another few hours, but Melog doesnt seem to mind as long as he is in her space. He spends the afternoon harassing Adora instead, swatting at the curtain when she is in the shower, balling himself up in her laundry basket when she tries to wash her clothes, and walking on the stove to prevent her from turning it on until she gives up and decides to fix a dinner that she can make in the oven. Melog watches with a look of smug victory as she slides the pan inside.

"Y oure a menace," Adora informs him. Melog mews and stands up, walking over on the counter and butting his head out for pets. Despite the scolding, Adora gives them to him. She really does love him. All of his antics remind her of how Catra was when they were kids. Actually, she's still like that now, she's just usually more subtle about it. She pets Melog until she gets tired of standing there – when she gets home from a shift she's usually ready to collapse – and she heads into the living room to lay out on the couch. Given how needy Melog has been, she expects him to follow her and demand more attention, but he stays in the kitchen, apparently standing guard over the oven.

He meows loudly in time with the timer when it goes off. Adora was *maybe* drifting off, but there was no way for *him* to know that, so she refuses to believe that he isnt just being annoying. When she stumbles back into the kitchen, it seems to be confirmed by the fact that Melog had made himself into a loaf on top of her oven mitts. Ordinarily Adora might coo annoyingly about what a good loaf he has made and how round he looks, but as it is, she narrows her eyes at him. t has been up in the air on if he wanted attention or simply to be annoying all evening and this seems to confirm the latter.

"Shoo," she orders him as she shuts the oven off and opens it up. Melog trills and wiggles his back end a little, as if to burrow down even more into the apparent comfort of the gloves. One glance at her food confirms that it is ready and she needs to take it out if she doesn't want it to start getting overdone. Adora tries to make a shooing motion, but he just looks back at her, unimpressed, and doesn't even try to swat at her. Of course he doesn't – that would mean lifting a foot and possibly giving her access to the mitts beneath him.

Adora huffs, glaring down at him as she puts her hands on her hips and does her best to emulate the look Angella gives him that makes him get up and leave her office. Melog blinks back and flicks an ear. He doesn't care. Adora wrinkles her nose up and glances back at the oven, propped open a crack and radiating heat, but still in danger of burning her food. As much as her friends joke that she will eat anything, she doesn't like *burned* things. She tries sending Melog a pleading look instead. He doesn't even blink at her this time.

"Please?" she asks, reaching down slowly and trying to pinch the very edge of the oven mitt out from beneath him. As her hand approaches, he growls, and she quickly withdraws. She actually has no idea if Melog would swat at her with his claws out now, but he certainly did it a lot when he was a feral kitten who didn't trust anyone that couldn't purr, so she isn't taking her chances. She doesn't want to have to go to the doctor to get antibiotics for a cat scratch – or worse, a *bite*.

She also doesn't want to eat burnt food. She narrows her eyes at him, thinking about how Catra would handle the situation. The problem is, she wouldn't need to handle it. She would just scoop Melog up like it's nothing – similar to how Adora did on Monday when he was in her helmet, and again when he was thrust upon her. Adora looks down at him still frowning. It can't be that simple. She has approached him as carefully as she can and he has hissed, growled, and swatted at her.

Catra will walk by him and pick him up in one hand without even pausing her stride. Catra is also certain that Adora shouldn't be having any trouble picking Melog up. For a long moment, Adora makes eye contact with Melog as she forms a theory that could very well lead to her having her face clawed off. It would be better to just *ask* Catra, but she has yet to volunteer any information about how to handle Melog and instead outright laughs in their faces when they can't deal with him on their own.

"Please don't be mad at me," Adora tells Melog, and then she takes a deep breath and swoops in, sliding her hands under him as fast as she can and scooping him up. All her instincts tell her not to make sudden movements around a feral cat and she half expects to be clawed, but instead Melog goes fucking *limp* and starts purring the moment that she tucks him against her chest. Adora gapes down at him as he sets to rubbing his cheek against her shoulder.

"It can't be that simple. *All* of us aren't that stupid," Adora says out loud, like Melog is going to answer her. Adora can see one or two of them missing the signals and patterns, but the entire firehouse sans Catra? That's a lot. Then again, Melog was decidedly more feral when they found him. It's possible that him allowing quick grabs is only a recent development and Catra was truly an exception for a long time. Adora moves to set Melog on the floor and he mews in protest, but reluctantly puts his feet under himself. He stares up at her with wide eyes from his banishment on the floor as she pulls on her oven mitts.

"No, I'm annoyed at you. I can't believe you're so bad at being a cat that it takes doing all the wrong things to handle you," she tells him. Melog mews again, almost if he's protesting. Adora knows that her annoyance won't last long – she can't say no to his cute little face – but for now she is determined to ignore him. As she finally gets to sit down to *eat* her dinner, Melog jumps up on the kitchen table and loafs in the spot where Catra's plate normally sits, watching her intently.

I'm not talking to you," she tells him, despite how she is very much doing that, and he probably isn't even interested in forgiveness and is just waiting for her to let her guard down so he can swipe something. He has gotten a lot better about stealing food over the last few months, but when Catra first pulled him out of the fire, he was starving. He was definitely a stray kitten that was just hunkering down in the building when it went up. At least Adora hopes so. Otherwise he was abused.

Whatever his life before, it occurs to Adora that he left it by being forcibly yanked away. Catra saw him and didn't hesitate to grab him. It was an emergency , there was no time to coax him into her arms. Adora stares at Melog across from her, having a *realization* about why he might prefer to be handled that way still. Melog just blinks back at her, slowly, tucking his tail around his paws.

"Alright, come here," Adora tells him, reaching out with her left hand. Melog mews softly, standing up and butting his head into the touch without hesitation. Yeah, apparently being demanding and abrupt is the language he understands. It's what Catra had to do to rescue him, and also just how she is in general. Adora scratches at the underside of his cheek as she takes another bite. She feels sad for him – well, sad for him *before*, he's as spoiled as he could be now – and despite him making her dinner a little extra crisp, she forgives him.

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When Catra comes home that night, it is to find Adora sprawled out on her bed with Melog melted into her lap as she reads a book that Mara loaned to her. Adora looks up to greet her and feels her breath catch at the blatantly affectionate look on Catra's face. It takes Adora several seconds to register she is looking down at Melog rather than

Adora, at which point Adora's lungs begin working again with some air of disappointment. Right.

"Finally figure him out?" Catra asks, already unzipping her jumpsuit. She usually doesn't touch anything in the apartment after work until she has stripped out of it and showered to avoid oil or anything else getting spread around, but she blows a kiss to Melog as she walks past Adora's bed to reach the dresser they are using as a "wall" between their beds in the single bedroom apartment. Melog lifts his head and watches Catra pull a change of clothes out of it with interest, but he remains semi-melted into Adora's lap.

"You could have just *told* me," Adora points out. Catra laughs, her tail twitching with amusement. To be a shit – and as revenge for Catra giving her grief – Adora reaches out and grabs it. She doesn't pull on it – she doesn't want to hurt Catra – but Catra immediately squeaks and twists to look over her shoulder with a flush high in her cheeks. She is effectively trapped, unable to walk away without causing Adora's hand to pull. Adora sends her a cocky grin. It's payback, but also she just likes seeing Catra's face all flushed. It's her favorite look on Catra, but she usually only sees it thanks to exertion.

"That wouldn't have been any *fun*," Catra huffs back, reaching down and swatting at Adora's hand. When that doesn't work, she grabs the base of her tail and pulls it out of Adora's grip herself. Adora reluctantly lets it go, but returning her hand to petting Melog just isn't the same.

"Can I brush you when you get out of the shower?" Adora asks. Catra's tail twitches and she looks over her shoulder to send Adora a glare, but the fact that she is still blushing cuts its impact. Adora gives her an innocent smile back. She just likes touching Catra and doesn't have a lot of excuses too, so brushing is always a good one. They both find the action soothing for various reasons. It's not exactly payback for Catra watching her struggle for months without offering a single piece of advice, but whatever, it's what Adora wants.

"Only if you stop acting like a baby whenever Melog is in your way ," Catra shoots back, closing the bedroom door behind her as she heads towards their shower. She doesnt even stay long enough for Adora to reply, but she makes a small shout of protest through the wall despite how it makes Melog give a displeased grumble in her lap. He flops his head dramatically against her, looking up at her with wide eyes as if to ask what he ever did to offend her. Adora huffs at him even as she scratches behind his ears.

"Y ou steal my Catra cuddles,"Adora informs him. Melog – because he is a cat who doesnt speak English, much less psychically communicates questions to her – ignores her , shutting his eyes and beginning to softly rumble as he drifts back off to sleep. He will undoubtedly abandon her the moment that Catra gets out of the shower to climb into her lap instead, but if Catra will sit and let Adora brush her, she can deal with Melog getting cuddles instead during it. This is compromise, she thinks.

She may love the stray, but she loves cuddling Catra more. Threats to her Catra time arent to be tolerated.

Chapter End Notes

This is very much just a fun little AU Im goofing around in and not taking too seriously. Chapter count is an estimate.
Firefighters: Adora, Glimmer, Mermista, Perfuma, Mara, Netossa, Spinnerella (and others).
Fire Engineer: Entrapta. (Fire engines: Emily & Darla).
Volunteer Firefighters: Catra (Mechanic), Scorpia (Tea shop).
Station Chief: Angella.
City Government: Hope.
EMTs: Bow & the Star Siblings (Starla, Jewel, and T ali Star).
Mechanics (outside of the firehouse): Catra, Lonnie, Rogelio.
Kyle works the desk.

Good Morning Etheria

Chapter Notes

This AU is like...half researched. I asked a firefighter some questions but there's others I didn't bother to even google. If something's wrong, I'm just saying they do things differently in Etheria LOL
POV alternates by chapter for this AU.
CW: Discussion of a non-violent transphobic action (a micro-aggression, I guess) and the fallout from that. No transphobia from the main cast, of course, but this chapter does kind of center around transphobia.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The newscaster has a generic voice – the kind you hear from just about every woman hosting the local news somewhere – but having made it up to the national stage, she has a bit more personality in her voice. Or maybe it's just from a history of cigarette use, it's hard to say.

"Firehouse 109 is unusual for a number of reasons. As you drive past it, you might notice the pride flag hanging outside. Once inside, you might be greeted by the station cat, a rescue that the crew pulled from a fire. As you look around, however, you may notice something even more unusual: everyone you will walk past, from the firefighters to their chief, is a woman."

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They have been featured on the news before – multiple times in fact. There was a news story about the controversy when they hung up

their pride flag and then a follow up a few days later. That was where Glimmer's iconic line of "You can't tell us not to exist and then ask us to save you" surfaced from. Melog has been on the news before too, because apparently having a station cat is quirky enough to bring the camera crews around on a slow day. There was a news story on the five-year anniversary of Angella becoming the city's first female fire chief too, though Catra wasn't there for that one.

All that coverage was from the local station, however. The clip about Melog ended up getting shared around pet accounts on social media, but they haven't gotten *that* much attention. This time, it's national. Catra doesn't know why this is even worthy of being such a news story. Female candidates tend to wash out of the academy for a lot of reasons, mostly related more to sexism and the patriarchy than anything else, but despite how the city likes to shove the B109 in front of any camera that is interested as a symbol for how progressive they are, Catra doesn't think they're *that* noteworthy.

The segment is probably part of some tourism board plan or something. Or maybe something bad happened in the city recently that they are trying to replace with some positive news. She bets if she googles Bright Moon hate crime" right now there will be a recent return, but between her "real" job and her commitment at the firehouse, she doesn't really have time to watch the news. She only watches the clip on them from *Good Morning Etheria* after it is uploaded on their YouTube channel. She is *in* it and she still doesn't have the time to scan through the full episode, though she knows that Adora recorded it.

A local crew came out to film the segment. They weren't told what show it was for at the time but they didn't really care. It seemed like a pointless fluff piece. A bit of voice over, some shots of them at work in the station, a few talking head interviews, and then some shots of them on the firetruck, driving to a 9-1-1 call where they weren't even needed in the end, though the show doesn't make mention of that. Catra wishes that an all-female firehouse didn't feel noteworthy, but

aside from that, she doesnt think anything of the clip when she watches it at work.

t' s a slow day, so while Lonnie and Rogelio are busy tag-teaming a broken-down pickup, Catra just finds herself scrolling around on her phone while she waits for something to do herself. She is grateful for slow shifts when she has a shift at the firehouse right after, but they're also a curse, because if Hordak walks through and sees Catra doing anything to entertain herself, even if there is no work to do, he's going to get pissed. That's why they have a warning system set up with Kyle over in reception, but he isnt the most observant even with Hordak having to walk right past him to leave his office.

When Catra hears the warning ding on the shop computer a few feet away from where she is lounging with her cellphone, she quickly turns it off and shoves it into the pocket of her jumpsuit. She doesnt get to see the very end of the clip, but she is sure it's just more of the same, and she doesnt particularly care. She was only there for one day of filming and, as one of the volunteer firefighters, she wasnt even interviewed for the segment. Adora has already been shown a decent amount in the segment and Catra doubts she is missing much. f she is, she will have to wait for later to watch it. Hordak stalks through on one of his "fun police" rounds and Catra makes her expression as zoned out and bored as it could be.

Satisfied that no one is doing anything other than working or suffering on his dime, Hordak continues on through the garage and out the other door. Hell be back in a few minutes and no one will be able to warn them of his approach from the other side. Catra resigns herself to watching Lonnie and Rogelio sweat while she waits for him to come back through. t' s not the most entertaining – Lonnie hasnt even done her the decency of unzipping her jumpsuit so she can appreciate a hot lady in a sports bra at work – but Catra isnt going to get fired for it. She needs to keep this job until Angella finally offers her the full-time position that she has implied Catra is getting as soon as they can afford another firefighter.

By the time that Hordak has walked back through and returned to his office, Catra has forgotten she didn't watch all of the video.

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Catra is doing her best to conserve her energy when she walks into her second shift. Adora has been living at the firehouse for two days and Catra hasn't been sleeping well as a result. Just because they have separate beds now that they're adults doesn't mean Catra knows how to sleep without Adora's steady breathing filling the room. Once they are both working at the station full-time and can just always be on the same shifts, it will be easier, but as it is Catra desperately takes any shifts that she can do while maintaining her paying job that also line up with Adora's.

Volunteers only get a small "thank you bonus" payment that isn't enough to live on, even with the two of them living together. Catra never intended to be a firefighter herself and only started volunteering when she got jealous of how much time Adora spent at the firehouse, but now she loves it. It's way better than her thankless job at Hordak's shop and she still gets to use her skills on the fire engines. It might be more demanding too, but it feels less so when she gets to be with Adora, and especially when she gets to see so much of Adora's life at the firehouse and knows there is nothing to be jealous of.

Not that every one of their coworkers isn't hot – you usually don't make it through training without a six-pack – but most of them are taken anyway, and though Perfuma will occasionally flirt with Adora, she doesn't seem to really mean it and the rest aren't interested in Adora at all. Actually, Catra gets flirted with more than Adora does. Well, if you can call what she and Glimmer do flirting. Glimmer is married anyway. Scorpia was *definitely* flirting with Catra when she

first started volunteering, but after a while she seemed to shift her focus over to Perfuma.

The point is, Catra was missing Adora and worried about losing her before she began volunteering too, but now the fire station and its residence have become like a second home to them both. Catra isn't feeling that social when she arrives, but instead of holing up in her truck until there is a call, she goes prowling around to find Adora. She finds her in the "living room," sprawled out on her back on the sofa and fast asleep despite the debate raging in the open kitchen just a few feet away. Catra's ears twitch as she walks by to curl up on Adora.

"I'm telling you, they cut every frame of her. We were supposed to be in the same interview but they insisted on doing us separately and now she isn't anywhere in the video," Mermista says with the exact same tone of voice she uses when she suspects a fire is arson. She gets kind of weirdly excited as if her true calling was being some kind of investigator. Catra frowns as she carefully climbs onto the couch and drapes over Adora. Adora is so used to her presence that she doesn't even wake, instead dropping the arm that was on the back of the sofa down to wrap around Catra's back and making a soft noise in her sleep.

"Isn't this a bit...conspiracy theory-ish?" Mara's voice asks. Catra doesn't even know who they are talking about, though it is pretty obvious what video they are talking about. Catra doesn't know why anyone who is a stranger to them would want to purposefully cut one of them from the video. Catra isn't in it, but neither is Scorpia. They were only interested in filming the full-time firefighters and that made sense to Catra. Everyone knew that going in.

"She's the only one of us who doesn't appear in the video. She was in one of these group pans and they cut it off halfway to keep from showing her. Don't tell me some producer didn't think that she conflicted with their *narrative*," Mermista returns, her voice hot. Catra pins her ears back, worried that Adora will wake up, but she appears to be thoroughly sacked out beneath Catra. Slowly, Catra shifts to

ease her phone out of her pocket. She pulls back up the video she was watching earlier in the day and, on mute, starts it playing again.

She can hear it playing in the kitchen too, distantly, as Mermista replays it to demonstrate her point. It is far enough away that it shouldnt wake Adora, at least not if the debate didnt. Besides, Catra is a bit too busy watching the video closely to be worried about Adora's sleep. Mentally, she counts each of the firehouse's residents off as they appear on the screen in interviews and shots of them around the firehouse. It is hard to keep track of them all in her head, but between the list she manages to keep and Mermista's words, it becomes glaringly obvious who is missing by the end.

Catra growls and buries her face against Adora's shoulder as she shoves her phone back into her pocket. Perfuma was missing. A whole segment dedicated to the all-female firehouse and there isnt one mention of the city's first transfeminine firefighter.

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By the time that Adora wakes up, everybody on-shift has come to reluctantly believe Mermista. Not that her argument isnt convincing, it's just that everybody wishes it wasnt true. When you are looking for it, however, it is pretty blatant. No one outside of the firehouse could really tell – you would have to know not only that Perfuma works there, but also that she was present during filming – but to the residents of B109, the situation seems pretty cut and dry.

The mood in the kitchen, where most of them are gathered, is somewhat livid. Perfuma isnt on-shift right now luckily – if she hasnt noticed for herself, there is no reason to make her feel bad by pointing it out – but the entire firehouse is indignant on her behalf. Perfuma went through a lot as a trans firefighter, especially because she was transitioning *while* attending the academy. She got bounced

around between three firehouses in a year before she managed to reach out to Hope. Hope is Mara's wife, but perhaps more importantly, she is a trans woman working in the city government.

Hope talked to Angella and pulled some strings. Perfuma's next assignment was at B109 and she was an instant fit. She started at the same time as Adora. When Catra started herself, Adora told her that Perfuma used to be more withdrawn and eager to please. She really wanted this assignment to work and she wasn't about to rock the boat. Having a boss married to a trans man was a big deal to her. She felt like she had at least one person in her corner and she didn't want to make enemies on the rest of the crew .

Even though Catra is glad that she isn't having to deal with this, she hopes that Perfuma would be happy to see how many people are riled up on her behalf. They chose to fly the nine-stripe pride flag instead of the more common one specifically because it included a stripe for diversity. It represented their firehouse and its crew better . There's something especially insidious about a segment ostensibly about celebrating women and the progressiveness of their firehouse leaving out the member who showcases that the best. It shows how performative the whole thing really is.

When Adora finds out – especially after she watches the segment again and sees all the points where Perfuma should have been mentioned or at least *seen* – her expression darkens. She ends up having to leave the debate in the kitchen to go blow off steam with the punching bag that Glimmer hung up from a crossbeam a year ago. Catra perches on top of a nearby locker and watches. She is pissed off as well, but she will never pass up an opportunity to ogle Adora.

Watching Adora's muscles flex as she sweats in her sports bra and tank top does help with the annoyance some. Catra wishes that there was something they could do, but they already came to the conclusion that they couldn't during the debate in the kitchen. They could try raising a fuss on social media, but none of them really have a following, and they're a little too busy *working* to start some kind of

campaign. Besides, Perfuma wouldnt want them to out her to the entire world.

She is out to them, but there's a difference between her friends knowing and inviting transphobia from across the nation. They cant accuse the show of transphobia without eventually drawing attention to who they were being transphobic against. They could try to avoid naming Perfuma, but if their accusations got any traction, someone would eventually dig into it and out Perfuma themselves. t wouldnt be hard to look at the firehouse's crew on the city website and realize who was missing from the clip.

"At least they didnt cut out our pride shit," Adora mutters as she hits the bag, sending a glance up to Catra. Catra nods absently. She doubts anyone brought up their sexuality in the interviews, but there are plenty of touches around the firehouse from pride flag colors to the *Girls Bang Girls* sticker Mermista put up on her locker two years ago. Catra is pretty sure that the sticker didnt make it into the program, at least not close up enough to be readable, but there were plenty of little things that they didnt cut out. They even acknowledged the pride flag out front.

t only makes the piece seem more performative and bigoted given that they specifically cut the trans woman from it, but it does give Catra an idea.

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Angella takes no convincing. Catra knew that she wouldnt. n fact, she didnt even ask before going to buy the flag kit. Theyll probably end up on the local news again, but who cares. Theyll be able to make their stance clear without drawing too much attention. Catra knocks on Angella's office door and, when she is called in, sets the kit on her desk. t was shipped in discreet packaging – and doesnt

that say a lot – so Angella raises a brow at her and has to turn the package over to read its label before she realizes what it is.

"For out front, I presume?" she asks, looking up to make eye contact with Catra. Catra nods. Everyone on the crew knows about Perfuma being cut from the piece by now, even if no one mentions it in front of her. It's not a secret or anything – after all, she has watched the video too and her silence about it leaves no doubt that she has noticed her absence from it – but it would just be a jackass thing to do to rub it in her face that some strangers decided she wasn't "woman enough." Since the crew knows, Angella knows. Glimmer undoubtedly ranted to her about it at some point, but Angella also generally knows about the going-ons at the firehouse.

"They didn't cut *that* from the piece," Catra offers as she folds her arms. They already chose their pride flag to send a message, but it can't hurt to add a trans pride one too. Well, it could piss some people off, but Catra considers that more of a bonus than anything else. The corner of Angella's mouth quirks up as she reaches for a pair of scissors on her desk and slices open the package.

"I don't suppose you mind being the one to put it up?" she asks as she pulls the flag and its mounting kit out. It is going to be a bit of a pain, but Catra immediately shakes her head and reaches out for the kit. She wouldn't have bought it if she intended to foist it off on someone else. Well, maybe on Adora, but she sees things through, thank you very much. Angella gives her a small nod, handing the mounting kit off to her. Clearly she approves.

"I'll do it as soon as I have downtime," Catra promises her, tucking the box under her arm as she steps back to head for the door. Angella gives her a slight nod of dismissal and turns back to her computer, still sporting a weirdly-proud smile on her face. Angella is almost a parental figure to some of them at the firehouse, but it is especially weird – and needed – for Adora and Catra who never really had one thanks to getting kicked around in the foster system growing up. Catra is still getting used to getting that kind of feedback. She always feels like she did good when she gets it though.

She doesnt leave the of fice bouncing on her heels – she isnt *Adora* – but the tip of her tail twitches with satisfaction as she goes.

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"That was sweet of you," Adora tells Catra while looking at her with puppy dog eyes. Catra doesnt know why she looks like she' s pleading for something when she doesnt actually want anything from Catra. This is just the way that Adora has always looked when Catra does something that she deems thoughtful, especially for anyone other than Adora herself. t dates back to when they were kids and Catra was… *territorial* – at best – of Adora. Their foster home was rough and Catra couldnt really af ford to care about anyone other than her best friend.

They're approaching a decade on aging out of the home, though, and things havent been like that for a long time. Catra took awhile to warm up – or process her trauma, however you want to phrase it – afterwards, but she's a first responder now. She regularly risks her life for other people. Adora looks at her this way sometimes at the end of emergency calls, actually, but you would think saving lives would make *putting up a flag* not even register on the scale anymore.

"Just making a point to the assholes," Catra grunts back as she tries to reach deeper into the engine. Someone – she has no proof of who, but she can fucking guess – swatted a bolt down into it when she had her back turned. Melog is now mysteriously curled up on the roof of the fire engine while Catra is left to try to fish it out with her claws or whatever tools she can fit into the space. She doesnt want to leave it in there, but she also doesnt want to take the engine apart to fix it.

“Well, as a non-asshole, I also appreciate the point,” Adora returns. She is lounging behind Catra, tipped back in a chair and watching her work, smug in the fact that she can laze around while Catra does real work. Catra flicks her ear in acknowledgement as she tries to stretch *just* far enough to reach the bolt. Adora is an asshole sometimes – usually a smug one – but never of the variety that Catra is talking about. When she calls Adora an asshole, she usually does it while laughing. Catra put up the flag as a middle finger to bigots.

Perfuma definitely noticed. Adora told Catra that she asked around about it when she arrived to her next shift. Adora wasn't there either, but Mara is a weird combination of a mentor and a big sister figure to Adora and she told her about it when she came in this morning. Catra only arrived a few hours later after taking a shift at the Fright Zone. Mara said Perfuma seemed appreciative about it and Catra trusts her judgement. In fact, when it comes to social signals, Catra trusts her above Adora. Perfuma hasn't said anything to Catra thus far, but they also haven't run into each other.

Everyone knows that if she isn't in one of the living spaces, she is in the garage, so Perfuma could have found her easily once her shift started, but Catra isn't waiting for an acknowledgement. The flag was about sending a message and making *Perfuma* feel acknowledged, not the other way around. In fact, Catra would prefer that nobody but Adora acknowledge her effort. She likes it when Adora appreciates her – and of course she likes being appreciated in general – but she also feels extremely put on the spot when she is the focus of positive attention like that, at least outside of an emergency scene.

She is still growing accustomed to people thanking her for saving their lives, or their pets, or even just their belongings, but it has been easier to adjust to than people thanking her for being *nice*. Besides, she has an aloof badass reputation to uphold. When she sees Perfuma in the kitchen near the end of her shift, Perfuma gives her a small but very grateful smile and Catra just inclines her head in acknowledgement. Words don't need to be said to make this about

her. Perfuma is grateful, Adora is proud of her – as is Angella – and that's all she needs.

Chapter End Notes

Yes Catra, Adora is definitely sitting there to be all smug and absolutely not watching your ass or your back flexing as you bend over and sweat. Fucking dumbass.
Tried to walk the line between "doing something nice," "not making the person who was discriminated against deal with it" (because doing that all the time is exhausting), and also "dont make it all about a bystander who doesnt experience this type of discrimination."There was also the POV character bias to contend with, but hopefully that all worked out.
Im not accusing Good Morning America of being transphobic, Ive never watched the show , Ijust stole its name lmao.

Lesbian Activity

Chapter Notes

> Happy Valentines if Imanaged to get this up before midnight in your country lol
> Just realized that Ikeep forgetting to mention this on here: the AU's title is from the song Too Damn Hot by Alice Francis.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora cant wait for Catra to become a full-time firefighter . She knows that it will probably be months before it happens, maybe even longer, but she really misses her when she is on her long shifts living at the firehouse. Every short shift that Catra gets during those times brightens up Adora's day. Adora loves her job and her friends at the firehouse, but spending time there is even better when Catra is there too. They usually end up napping together if things are slow enough for them to sleep, just so they have an excuse to be wrapped up in each other.

Being a firefighter was the first job that Adora really wanted as a kid - well, the first one was "unicorn vet", but it turns out there are never openings for that position – but it can be a taxing life. Now that Catra has joined the firehouse, Adora cant imagine anyone ever doing this without their loved one working alongside them. She guesses that is where the burnout and fatigue come from that lead to people retiring. Not that Catra is her girlfriend or anything, but she is the closest thing that Adora has.

Alright, Adora is utterly in love with Catra and not even trying to deny it anymore - to herself, at least - but they are just best friends despite her daydreams. Still, it was sweet of Catra to join the firehouse despite already having a job. Catra never wanted to be an emergency responder and they were both aware from the moment

that Catra voiced the idea that she was doing it for Adora – well, for them.

The stress of their jobs was putting cracks in their relationship. They were fighting more than ever and Adora was terrified that Catra would move out when their lease was up despite having nowhere to go and no real way to pay for an apartment on her own. Catra talked like the firehouse stole Adora from her and turned her into a bad roommate – the latter is partially true, just because Adora was often too exhausted to clean or cook when she got home – and it felt like they were reaching a breaking point.

Adora couldn't have stood losing Catra, but she couldn't quit her job either, much less just *stop helping people*. She loves the work that she does, no matter how hard it is, and it's necessary. Someone has to do it and Adora wants to be the one. She told Catra a few times, during various fights, that she would understand *why* Adora gives everything she has to her job if she did it for herself and experienced everything she does. She never thought that Catra would put that to the test, though.

There's a distinct possibility that Catra joined the firehouse just to prove Adora wrong and that it would have been the final nail in the coffin for them, but it turned out to be fantastic not only for their relationship, but for Catra as well. She has really come into her own since starting, opening up in brand new ways. The look on her face when someone thanks her through tears for saving them says it all. Catra may not have grown up dreaming of pulling off daring rescues like Adora did, but she thrives off the exertion of the work and the positive attention that she gets.

Besides, by working on the fire engines with Entrapta she quickly found a way she can keep up her old trade despite switching careers. Catra definitely didn't plan to switch paths when she first started volunteering, but it's been a year now and the job offer seems inevitable the next time they have room on their permanent roster for a new addition. Adora can't wait. The only thing better than

getting to save lives and keep Catra *in* hers is getting to have her right there alongside her.

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Adora is living at the firehouse for the next few days, which means three things: she's sleeping in the bunk room, she's missing Catra, and she doesn't have Catra's cooking to rely on. Adora *can* cook, but it took her awhile to be anything except a disaster in the kitchen. She still isn't great at it, but she can make simple things. She just doesn't have whatever inherent sense of taste lets Catra walk into a kitchen, pull whatever out of the fridge, throw it together with spices she doesn't even measure, and have it turn out edible, much less *good*. They all tend to make group meals together at the firehouse, so Adora's cooking skills are weirdly specific on large meals.

When she has to make something for herself between meals, however, she misses Catra's cooking. Sometimes she gets it anyway – when she brings some leftovers from home or Catra has a shift too and sets up in the kitchen – but it is just another of the many things that Adora misses while she is staying there without her. She misses sharing a room with Catra, her gentle purrs as she sleeps, her quiet movement around the apartment, and the touches of her everywhere. Not that there aren't signs of Catra at the firehouse now – and Adora is grateful for them – but it is different from being in a space that *is* hers.

"You look like you didn't sleep," Catra drawls from the doorway. Adora startles, looking up and blinking at Catra. Catra smirks as Adora's jaw hangs open. She strolls into the kitchen and gets right in Adora's space so she can peer over her shoulder at her food, wrinkling her nose a little and dropping back down on her heels as she realizes it is slightly-burned sauteed carrots. Hey, at least Adora peeled and seasoned them. If she made this dish five years ago, she

likely would have left the greens on and set them on fire trying to cook the carrots without anything more than salt on them.

"We got calls while I was supposed to be sleeping," Adora defends. They have to sleep some time while they are living at the station, but if they get calls while they are trying to rest then they have to bolt up and get to work. After coming back from the last call, she was of course tired, but also hungry and starting to get grouchy about the interruptions. She decided to fix herself something to eat so she could at least be full even if she got woken up again. Catra snorts, hooking her chin over Adora's shoulder and nuzzling against the side of her neck.

Adora draws in a breath just a little too quick, feeling her cheeks flush. Luckily Catra can't see it from behind her back. Adora tries to stamp down on her stupid flush and rising libido as Catra presses more firmly against her back and hugs her from behind to get better leverage so she can scent mark the side of Adora's neck. Adora's heart thuds in her chest. She tries to stamp down on any visible or audible reactions to Catra's affection. Luckily, Catra begins to purr, which helps to cover up Adora's racing heartbeat a little. The flipside of that is that Catra's rumbling also makes Adora's flush darken.

She's fucking in love with her best friend and sometimes it's really hard to pretend otherwise. They have always been affectionate and only got more so after joining the firehouse – everyone at the firehouse is unusually touchy and it has normalized some behavior between them that most friends wouldn't engage in – but sometimes Adora still yearns for things that she can't have. Sometimes it's as simple as wanting more of something that she gets occasionally – she would love for Catra to greet her like this every time they see each other and not just when they have been apart for a while – and sometimes it's things like picturing turning around and kissing her.

She puts the latter under the *bad thoughts* category. Getting hugs more often might be acceptable between friends, even if they are already super touchy. Turning around and walking Catra back until she bumps into the kitchen counter so Adora can kiss her for

minutes on end? Absolutely not. Catra is only marking her now because she missed her. Catra loves marking. It's not as deep as Adora would like it to be, but it just feels so intimate when Catra nuzzles against her and rubs her cheek on her , especially when she starts purring too.

"You wanna get back in bed when you're done eating your charcoal? Shit was frantic at the Fright Zone. I could use a nap," Catra asks as she settles with her cheek pressed against Adora's shoulder, still purring. Adora would protest that her carrots are *barely* burnt, but she is worried that her voice wouldn't come out steady – or sounding anything approaching normal – so she just nods instead. She loves helping people, but there had better not be any fires in the next few hours. She wants to cuddle up with Catra and get lost in her softness.

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Catra, like in most things in her life, requires some special equipment to do her job. Not that it's *really* special – that assumes that human is the default – but it is different from what everyone else at the firehouse uses. Scorpia, similarly, needs special equipment as well, but scorpioni are better adapted to deal with heat. Catra, conversely, could easily be badly burned by a stray cinder in her fur. The torso of her uniform is the same, as are her gloves – she can just retract her claws, after all – but her pants have a modified sleeve for her tail attached to the back and her helmet is a completely different design with raised ridges over her ears so they can be at least partially unfurled and allow her to use her superior hearing to some degree.

All the equipment is mass produced, not tailored – hence the gradual ridges for ears rather than two cones for them that would have to match up exactly with their positions on her head – and it doesn't fit perfectly. Firefighter equipment isn't comfortable for *anybody*, but

Catra in particular ends up with earaches from having them folded up in her helmet, not to mention her fur getting pinched and pulled in the suit. There was a brief period where she was worried it was leading to hair loss, but it turned out that she was shedding a regular amount and it only looked like more because everything was coming off inside the suit rather than being spread across all her clothes and sprinkled around throughout the day – and in the shower drain.

f they are on an emergency call that doesnt involve a fire or anything else that would mean they need a helmet, Catra usually leaves her helmet in the truck, but if she does have to wear it for an extended period of time, then she often spends a while after taking it off flicking her ears compulsively until they start feeling normal again. Today they had an emergency call about kids playing in a condemned building and had to wear their helmets when they went looking for them in case the ceiling collapsed on them. When they get out on the street again, Catra takes her helmet off as soon as the kids have been passed off to the police so they can find their parents.

The good Samaritans who saw the kids and called it in are gone, so her fellow crew and other emergency responders are the only ones around to see Catra's ears twitching and flicking adorably on either side of her head as they head back to the truck. Adora sits in the passenger seat and watches Catra the whole way back to the firehouse. Catra can see her staring in her periphery, but she is a responsible driver when she is at Emily's wheel and she glares at the road rather than Adora.

"Stop that," she orders. Her ears are still quivering and her cheeks are lightly dusted pink. Adora grins.

"Nope," she tells her . Someday she is going to afford buying Catra a custom-fitted helmet that wont make her ears bend, but despite wishing her current helmet didnt cause her discomfort, the way that Catra flicks her ears afterwards is adorable. Adora is going to enjoy the one positive that comes out of it, even if it makes Catra huff and blush as she drives them back.

After they arrive at the station and have put away their gear, Adora flops down on one of the couches and pats her lap hopefully. Catra raises an eyebrow at her even as she approaches and sits down beside Adora. Melog isn't anywhere in sight or Adora is certain that he would jump in her lap exclusively because she isn't trying to invite him.

"C'mere. I'll rub your ears," Adora offers, patting her lap again. Catra's ears immediately prick up, excitement at the prospect obvious. Adora smiles to herself as Catra huffs as if to pretend she doesn't care, but she flops over and settles with her head in Adora's lap without hesitation, her tail thumping against the couch steadily with her excitement. Adora drops her hands to the bases of Catra's ears and begins to rub, quickly drawing a rumbling purr out of Catra. For a few moments, the thumping of her tail speeds up, and then it slows and goes limp as she melts into Adora's lap.

She's so *cute* that Adora doesn't know how to begin processing the ball of emotion in her chest. She wants to squeal, she wants to hug her, and she wants to cover Catra in kisses. She wants things that she doesn't even know, only able to identify the yearning for something she doesn't have right now. She settles for grinning down at Catra like a madwoman. Catra's eyes fell closed the second Adora set to rubbing her ears, so she isn't watching Adora smile like an idiot at just seeing her content. She can't help it. Having a purring Catra in her lap is a kind of bliss – for them both, she supposes, since Catra only does it when she is content.

Adora can't do much to help with the more intense earaches that Catra gets after a prolonged rescue operation, but this helps with the milder ones and Catra likes it even when she isn't hurting. Besides, it gives them an excuse to get pretty cuddly. Adora will happily rub at Catra's ears until her hands get too tired to keep it up or they get another call. Catra certainly isn't going to get up until Adora stops. Adora likes having her best friend melted in her lap.

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"Call the doctor , it's terminal," Mermista mutters under her breath. Adora, still watching Catra as she talks to the EMTs, elbows Mermista pointedly. Catra is too far away to overhear Mermista's jokes about Adora' s gayness over all the sirens at the scene, but still, it's the principle. Next time Catra might not be far enough away . Right now Catra's ears are twitching as she tucks her helmet beneath her arm, having just pulled it off and made Adora's heart stop. Adora can't help it. She' s just so…

"*Look at her* . Can you blame me?" Adora mutters back, only pouting a little bit. Even from here, Adora can see how Catra is lit up, alive with the adrenaline rush that comes along with their job. The injuries were minor and they can be satisfied with a job well done. Adora can take a few moments to appreciate her best friend from a distance before Catra turns around and they start loading up the truck. Mermista snickers. Adora is sure she is exchanging looks with the rest of her supposed friends behind her back.

Adora's crush is, unfortunately, *known* . Her friends claim that it's obvious, but Adora maintains that's because the rest of their crew doesn't know their history together . It was a slow build to get to the point where they are now. If Adora started acting this way around someone she just met, it would be obvious what was going on, but she and Catra have been best friends for their entire lives and it leads to a lot of easy comfort with each other. They shared not only a bunk bed but sometimes a *mattress* at their foster home, after all. The top bunk wasn't totally stable and Catra often slept on Adora instead.

Of course they don't mind falling asleep on each other now . Of course Catra wants to scent mark Adora and her stuff – for a long time, there was no separator between *Adora* and *Catra*. That applied to both their things and their lives. Having each other was the only way they made it through their rough childhood, but in many ways

there still isnt a division. h fact, they started to fall apart when their jobs forced a division to form.

All the things that make it look like Adora is hopelessly obsessed with Catra are just how their friendship has always been. Mermista can pretend to be shocked when Adora says something that makes it clear they arent dating as many times as she wants. The joke is old and not going to change the reality of their situation. They are far too inextricably linked for Adora to risk making a move. Their beds are a foot apart at home and they have to change next to each other at work. Everything would get horribly fucked up if Catra wasnt comfortable with Adora's advances.

The best-case scenario that Adora can imagine is Catra moving out and switching to volunteer at a different firehouse. h that scenario, the new direction that Catra's life is headed in isnt ruined even if their friendship is. h the worst-case scenario, Catra disappears from her life entirely and retreats to her miserable job at the Fright Zone, losing her entire social circle and support system. Adora isnt going to drive her to that. Their lives are so good right now, it's greedy of Adora to want more.

Sometimes she cant help it though. Sometimes she swears that she catches Catra looking at her the same way. Sometimes the teasing of the rest of their crew gets to her and she wonders if Catra is running through the same circles of justification in her head, also kept quiet by fear . Then she remembers that is ridiculous. Catra isnt afraid to act on what she is feeling, even if she isnt one for talking about it. t has gotten her in trouble more than once. She used to be outright volatile thanks to her tendency to act out of emotion.

She would have kissed Adora long ago. Catra isnt interested, so it isnt an option for Adora to even explore. She has to settle for these stolen moments as she watches Catra chat with Bow . At least their crew hasnt said anything to Catra about it. They may tease, but this is one line they know not to cross.

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Scorpia only started volunteering after Catra did. Actually, Adora is pretty sure she was inspired to volunteer by Entrapta mentioning that one of her coworker's friends was training to volunteer alongside her. Scorpia, similarly to Catra, joined to spend more time with her friend and roommate, though their situation was definitely different. They weren't fighting and Entrapta wasn't in love with Scorpia, for one. Given the things that Scorpia has said and done since joining, Adora can't help but suspect that she also joined to meet Entrapta's hot coworkers.

When she joined, Catra was spending a lot of time with Entrapta as she learned the engines and all but wooed her into letting her get her hands on Emily. At the time, Mara was her primary driver, but Catra desperately wanted to get her hands on the trucks. Adora is pretty sure that it gave her a sense of normalcy, something she knew that she would be good at as she learned the ropes of everything else. The training that volunteers go through before starting isn't the same thing as being in the field for real and it was a big adjustment. Catra was – and still is – gunning to be an engineer once she had the required experience under her belt.

Wanting to be an engineer, for Catra at least, meant spending time studying under their current one. With Catra spending a lot of time with Entrapta, though, she also ended up hanging around Scorpia by association. Adora didn't mind it until she realized that Scorpia was flirting with Catra regularly. Adora tried to react normally to it, but she felt something hard to describe. She had never felt it before, or at least not as strongly.

When Glimmer saw the look on Adora's face as she listened to Scorpia very obviously ask Catra on a clumsy date over in the next room, she whistled and mouthed *jealous* to her. Catra either didn't realize what Scorpia meant by *a game night at my place* or wasn't interested because she brushed Scorpia off by saying she was too

busy to go anywhere other than one of her jobs right now. It wasn't the last time that Adora heard Scorpia trying way too hard to engage with Catra. When Adora tried to bring it up to Catra in a normal, totally not jealous way, Catra always just shrugged it off.

That maybe made Adora even more jealous. Scorpia could openly flirt with Catra while Adora had to steal side-long looks and *hope*. The next time Scorpia said something a little too *much* in the locker room, Adora muttered about *work place harassment.* Scorpia immediately shut up – as did everyone else. It got awkwardly silent for a long time as they continued to change, and then Perfuma struck up an awkward conversation and after a few minutes, the weird tension that entered the air dissipated.

"She wasn't *harassing* me," Catra scoffed as they drove home that night. Adora's hands tightened on the wheel.

"She wasn't taking the hint," was the only justifiable response Adora could think of. That was something that would have annoyed Adora even if she didn't have feelings for Catra. It was pretty much the definition of harassment, however mild it was. Scorpia didn't stop all at once after that incident, but she got a lot more cautious and unsure. A week or two later, she was spending more time with the others at the firehouse rather than just hanging around Catra or Entrapta.

It took a few weeks of Scorpia not hitting on Catra, but Adora eventually warmed up to her. She's sweet, even if she doesn't take a hint well. Still, Adora sometimes feels a twinge of jealousy when she walks in a room and finds Catra, Entrapta, and Scorpia all hanging out, laughing and talking easily. She can't forget that Catra and Scorpia could easily be *something* without ruining everything. Scorpia has no plans to become a full-time firefighter, instead destined to take over her moms' tea shop. If they started dating and it broke bad, their entire lives wouldn't fall apart. Scorpia could easily stop volunteering or switch to another firehouse.

"You have that look on your face again," Glimmer comments. Adora twitches, instinctively elbowing behind her, but Glimmer is too far back for her to hit. She snorts as she walks up and leans over the railing beside Adora. Catra and her two unlikely friends are out in the driveway doing some kind of maintenance on Emily. Adora wandered into the garage and has been hanging back near the railed ramp down from its raised section.

"Not far enough," Adora mutters. They are far enough away to talk quietly even with Catra's superior hearing, but not without likely seeming suspicious. Glimmer rolls her eyes and sends Adora a look. Adora steadfastly refuses to look back at her as Catra laughs about something that Entrapta said. She's in just her pants and the stained tank top she often wears under her uniform. It's killing Adora.

"You could at least go up and join them instead of watching like a creep," Glimmer points out, not dropping the topic despite the obvious hint. She is at least talking relatively quietly and not being *too* obvious with her words. Adora lets out a *hmph* and ignores her. Catra knows Adora is here – she waved to her when she came out – but she is hanging out with her friends right now, on top of doing actual work, so Adora doesn't want to interrupt.

"I was taking a moment to myself," she says, a bit louder. Maybe Catra can hear, if one of the other two doesn't talk over her. Glimmer raises an eyebrow, but it's *true*. Adora is allowing herself a quiet moment to just watch her best friend be happy. As tumultuous as Adora felt about Scorpia when she started, she is now firmly Catra's friend – and that is *it*. Adora can appreciate Catra just being happy around her without feeling the same raging jealousy that she once did.

"You came to the garage for a moment alone," Glimmer repeats, her voice making it clear that she isn't buying Adora's bullshit for a second. It definitely wasn't what Adora intended when she came out, but she just shrugs. It is what she is doing *now*.

I'll come back inside in a few minutes," she tells Glimmer. Glimmer sighs, but she pushes off the railing and turns to head back for the door. Adora doesn't doubt that she intends to prod at Adora once she goes inside and is firmly out of earshot of Catra, but she is grateful for the temporary reprieve. She returns to silently watching as Glimmer walks away. Catra glances her way when the garage door slams behind Glimmer and Adora offers her a smile. She thinks she gets one back, but Catra was already smiling a little, so it's hard to really tell.

She doesn't seem bothered by Adora's lurking. She turns right back to Perla and returns to working, anyway. If Catra isn't bothered, Adora doesn't know why Glimmer is. She isn't just standing here pining – well, okay, she *is*, but she is always doing that. Watching Catra isn't some signal that the yearning is tearing her apart or anything. She would quietly watch Catra do things going back to their childhood. If anything, this helps with her longing. She gets to watch Catra and just *feel* without being worried about being caught out.

She will go inside in a few minutes if only to avoid Glimmer coming back out to get her, but for now, she lets herself take in the amused twitching of Catra's tail and thinks about how grateful she is to have her.

Chapter End Notes

> Adora's comments to Scorpia did kind of cow her, but really after that incident Mermista pulled Scorpia aside and was like "Yeah, Catra and Adora are utterly infatuated with each other and no one else has any chance" and Scorpia was eventually forced to accept the truth lmao

The Charity Calendar

Chapter Notes

> Im pro-doing-whatever-the-fuck-you-want with your body , there's just limits to what individual people are comfortable with. And Catra's jealous lol.
> Ialso realized Iaccidentally left Netossa and Spinnerella off the list of firefighters at the beginning, so that's been fixed.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first time that someone said the words "charity calendar" Catra didnt react because she thought it was a *joke* . Firefighter calendars are either totally staged with random male models or made by specific departments to raise funds. They dont have anything they particularly need to fundraise for, and it was a stupid idea, so Catra was sure it was a joke – and maybe it was. At first. Eventually , however, Glimmer was saying it a bit too frequently . Then Adora started too.

Then the sign-up sheet appears. Catra walks into work, stares at it, and immediately goes to hunt down Adora, once again living at the firehouse for a few days. She is asleep when Catra finds her, but for once Catra doesnt care, because Adora's name was *second on the list*. Catra doesnt hesitate to climb on top of her in the bunk, half pinning her and half shaking her awake. Adora makes a sleepy, confused sound as she blinks her eyes open and squints up at Catra.

"What the hell is up with Glimmer 's fake sign-up list?" Catra demands, not even waiting for Adora to fully wake up. As emergency responders, they have to cultivate the ability to leap up and get to work at a moment's notice, so it doesnt take *long* for Adora's eyes to come into focus, but she still looks confused, frowning up at Catra.

"Fake sign-up list?" she echoes. Her sleep rough voice is adorable, not to mention the confused pinch to her brow, but Catra has *priorities* and it is making sure that this whole thing is a prolonged bad joke. Glimmer might have made it up exclusively to torture Catra, actually. Given the close quarters they are often in with their coworkers, not to mention the high emotions of their job, Catra is pretty sure she has done something that makes her feelings a little too obvious in front of every single one of her coworkers at least once. She makes sure to steal her sidelong glances at Adora whenever she isn't looking, but she would never get to take them if she waited for when the rest of the crew was averting their eyes as well.

"For the dumb charity calendar Glimmer has been joking about," Catra returns. Adora blinks, the confusion on her face clearing, but she doesn't roll her eyes and make a joke like Catra expects her to – or rather, like she *wants* her to. Instead, she just stares up at Catra for several seconds too long for a *just kidding* to be coming. Adora glances away, her cheeks slightly pink when she looks back.

"It, uh, isn't a joke. At least not anymore. If the department can raise donation funds before the end of the year, we might be able to get another hire approved," Adora explains. Her eyes are bright now, watching Catra carefully as she stares down at Adora, processing that information. It is very clear what Adora means: they do this calendar – successfully, at least – and Catra might just get the full-time position that she has been coveting.

"Do you *know* what a firefighter calendar usually is?" Catra hisses in response, feeling her face turning red. She can't let the temptation of getting to be with Adora all the time distract her from what she is actually proposing. Adora's own blush quickly darkens, but she sends Catra an almost shy smile, wriggling a little to free her arms from where they are awkwardly trapped at her sides and then placing her hands on Catra's own, which are still resting on her shoulders. She squeezes gently and gives Catra a weirdly hopeful look.

"We'll be *decent*. Tank tops or sports bras maybe. And there will be one or two where we're all kitted up. It won't be that raunchy," Adora offers. Catra stares down at her, imagining Adora in one of those stereotypical shirtless photoshoots, just the pants of her uniform on and her abs oiled. *Fuck*. If that becomes something that exists, she might never look away from it. On the other hand, she doesn't want anyone *else* to see it either.

"It's going to be a pride calendar too. That was Perfuma's idea. We'll all have our flag colors in the background or painted on our cheeks or something. Might help to keep straight guys from leering so much. And we'll also be raising for the queer youth group downtown, especially if we get more than our donation goal," Adora adds, almost as if reading her mind, though Catra is sure that she is just trying to talk her into it. Catra sighs, dropping her head down and burying her face in Adora's shoulder. Adora somewhat tentatively shifts her hands to Catra's back and hugs her a little as Catra thinks.

The thing is, Catra wants this job. She wants the validation of being hired, she wants all the time with Adora, and she wants to not be *exhausted* from working two jobs at once. Being a firefighter won't pay better than being a mechanic, but thanks to Hordak's stinginess it won't really pay worse. She is already looking forward to the idea of falling asleep with Adora every night, living at the firehouse together when it is necessary.

"Fuck, they're doing this, aren't they?" Catra groans and Adora crows with victory, already knowing what that means. Well, if she thinks Catra is letting her do this *alone* for her then she has another thing coming.

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The calendar is, unsurprisingly, controversial. They end up on the news before they have even shot it. The story is just a few minutes, but it covers the hot debate taking place on Facebook ever since they announced it. The local internet is split about whether this is sexualizing women or a win for equality. And of course there are the bigots riled up about it, but they're used to that by now. Glimmer says it is good – more people know about this than any of the other department charity events that have happened in recent memory, or maybe ever – but Catra reads a few gross comments before she decides not to look at anything posted about it, whether on Facebook or on the news.

She's taking part in it one way or another. She might be a bit uncomfortable with the idea of guys leering at the pictures, but it already has shown promise of spreading in lesbian circles throughout the state if the buzz that Spinnerella has been reporting is accurate. If that happens, then they should meet their goal and be able to help the youth group as well. Moreover, she knows this whole thing is at least partially for her benefit and she isn't going to let the others do it and then not take part herself. And maybe she just wants to be there for Adora's shoot. She's a lesbian, okay, she'll take the excuse to watch her best friend be sexy.

Most of the firehouse crew is pretty excited for the shoot. Not everyone is participating – well, everyone will be in the fully-kitted out group shot they're doing, but not everyone is participating in the other shots. Most of them will be wearing their uniform pants along with their undershirt – including Catra – but one or two of them have opted for a sports bra instead. Adora volunteered to do that until Catra elbowed her extremely pointedly – actually it was more like Catra punched her in the gut with her elbow – and Adora coughed out that she would actually take a shirt.

Everyone in the room gave Catra such knowing looks that she was at risk of starting a fire in her own cheek fluff with the intensity of her blush, but there was no way that Catra was letting there be basically-topless photos of Adora out in the world for other people to look at. If

someone can't feel her abs in person then they shouldn't be able to look at them either. The rest of their crew might be onto Catra, but Adora doesn't question her , at least not during the planning meeting. Catra thinks she has gotten away with it, but it was a big reaction – she couldn't *help* it – and she should have known better than to think that Adora wouldn't ask her about it.

"So, uh, why am I not allowed to wear a sports bra?" Adora asks, *extremely* awkwardly, as she drives them home that night. There's a weird tilt to her voice that causes Catra's fur to bristle with the fear of discovery, but she is wearing a jacket and Adora can't see it. If she could, whatever suspicion she has might grow. Catra shifts slightly to pin her tail between her leg and the seat so Adora can't see it twitching tensely from the driver's seat, at least not if she wants to keep her eyes on the road. She folds her arms and looks out the passenger window to make it hard for Adora to read her expression just for good measure.

"Say whatever bullshit you want about fundraising goals, but I don't want you baring skin on my behalf," Catra tells her , gruffly. She is keenly aware that the reason they need donation funds is at least partially to hire her. Nothing raised in this campaign will actually go to her, but if they can cover all their department's needs, then they don't have to ask the city for special maintenance funds and might be able to leverage that for another full-time position. They really could use it. Without their volunteers, they wouldn't be able to deal with their workload, and many volunteers can't keep dedicating that much time without reimbursement, at least not long-term.

Catra only started because of Adora, but even with that motivation, volunteering and working isn't something she can keep up forever . She needs the firehouse to turn into her full-time job if she wants to keep doing it. She gives herself a few months at best before the strain starts causing her and Adora to fight again, ruining this blissful period that they are in. She doesn't know what she would do then. She doesn't want to give this place up – the crew and their work has

come to mean a lot to her – but if a job offer wasn't on the horizon, she doesn't know how she would last.

"It's not like that," Adora returns from the driver's seat, but her voice is quiet. She would be a lot louder and more passionate if she truly disagreed – or at least if she didn't see Catra's point. Catra grunts, still sulking by looking out the window. That does make it sound like... well, like Adora is taking on a job that neither of them has to pay Catra's way into the station. That isn't what is happening. Still, her point is made. In the meeting, they were talking about hyping each other during the photoshoot before they got to the question of what everyone would wear. It sounded like it would be exciting then, but they have to remember what will happen with these photos in the end.

Just because they like to take off their shirts and flex for each other in the locker room to show off doesn't mean that they shouldn't think twice about doing it for the calendar. Mara had already decided to do it and Adora following after her like a puppy is likely why Adora instantly volunteered as well, but Catra put a stop to that. Her own photo is going to be something with Melog, because he's her cat and he should definitely be in the calendar, so it will be less on the sexy side. Catra is more than willing to cheer on her friends, but it isn't for her, and she would rather it wasn't for Adora either.

The charity calendar will make a point, help people, and be fun to shoot. Now that she knows Adora's shirt is staying on, she thinks she will be able to just enjoy shooting it.

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Catra is the first one up to shoot for the day just because there's a lot of activity and Melog wants to run and hide from all the strangers. They decide to shoot with him first so he can then retreat into

Angella's office and ignore the impromptu shooting studio that has been set up in the vehicle bay. The photographer brought a whole set with lighting and backdrops. Some of the shots will be done around the firehouse, however, like Catra's.

She sits in Emily's driver's seat, her knee propped up on the dash and Melog draped over her lap. She tries to look like she is lounging comfortably while also staying in shot and keeping Melog calm. He isnt *panicked*, but he doesnt like the photographer awkwardly crawled up on a ladder and Emily's hood so he can shoot through the polished front window. There was no other way for them to get this shot. Catra doesnt know why they didnt just shoot elsewhere then, but she went where the photographer told her to go.

She has a dog tag with the sunset stripes of the lesbian pride flag around her neck. The necklace actually belongs to Mara, but they will be passing it around between them today for some of the shots, along with the bi-flag variant that Glimmer has, though hers is in the shape of a heart. Entrapta already has her own nonbinary pride pigtail holders that she is sporting for the shoot. Catra actually quite likes the necklace and is now considering getting one of her own, but making sure it stays visible is another factor she has to juggle as they try to get the shot.

She has on the same clothes that she usually wears when she is working on the fire engines. They wanted to show the different sides of their job with this calendar . Engineer is an important position, but not one that people necessarily think of. Catra is probably the most covered up that any of them will be today, especially once Melog climbs up her chest and nuzzles under her chin for comfort. Catra cant help but grin as she begins petting him. The photographer snaps a photo while Catra's hand is relatively still and one look at the viewfinder confirms that it's the one.

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They haven't finalized whose photos will be on which months so far, though they did plan for Catra to go in January just because putting Melog early seemed like a good strategy to draw in the crowd that likes cats. The shooting order is determined by convenience as a result. Several of them do shots in front of the backdrops that the photographer brought, all abstract gradients of colors based on their pride flags. Most of them gather around and encourage each other while they're taking photos, hyping each other up and trying to get them to forget the camera so they can take natural-looking shots – none of them are models and this is new territory – but when it comes time for Adora's shot, Catra doesn't know what to say.

She's trying not to be a flustered mess. She sees Adora dressed like this every day – hell, Adora hangs out in t-shirts and boxers back in the apartment – but it's different when she is *trying* to be sexy. Adora is grinning and cocky and *flexing* for the camera. Catra is just trying to control the blush she didn't have when the others were shooting. She wishes she had done her shot in her full uniform now because the heaviness of the tail sock would have helped with how her tail wants to lash now. Their crew keeps sending her side-long looks. Glimmer especially has a shit-eating grin.

Catra knows their crew is well-aware of the lingering looks that she sends Adora, but they don't need to be so *obvious* about their teasing. Adora might catch on and that would be the end of everything. Luckily, Adora seems to be a little busy peacocking right now. She sends a smug glance *directly* at Catra before she tucks her thumbs into her uniform pants and leans back, cocky and flexing her arms since she can't show off her abs. Catra's mouth is dry. She can't believe that this turns her on, but it does. She is so glad she already did her shot. She doesn't need the blush on her face immortalized on camera.

Glimmer sidles up alongside Catra and she immediately tenses, waiting for whatever awful comment she is about to make that Adora just might overhear.

"I'm looking forward to when we move on to the gym," she says, her voice trying to be casual but still far too smug to fake it. Catra's tail lashes behind her. She can feel her cheeks blazing.

"I need to go change," she mutters, turning and walking away before Adora can look over and see her. She is supposed to be wearing her regular uniform for a group shot with the entire firehouse later and she does need to change at some point, but there is no reason for her to do it right now. Really she just needs to get away and take a breather so she can be *normal*.

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Catra is relieved to find Adora is done by the time she comes back. Adora actually *pouts* when she reappears.

"Where'd you go?" she asks. Catra almost feels more flustered by Adora's reaction to her going missing for a few minutes than she did when she was flexing, but at least she isn't blushing too much anymore. She doesn't know why Adora cares, but she gestures at herself pointedly.

"Had to change for the group shot," she points out. Adora's eyes flick down and then she looks back up to Catra's eyes. She's still pouting, but she doesn't say anything. Catra doesn't usually hang out in her full uniform – honestly, changing early might have been a bad call, she might be tired from wearing it all by the time that they take their final shot – but she needed the excuse to leave. She didn't put on her helmet, at least, so she doesn't have to deal with that. Adora's pout doesn't last too long. She rejoins the rest of them in cheering on those who are shooting, but she really perks up when they move to the gym.

Mara's shot is supposed to be her boxing in her sports bra with a lesbian pride band and straps. She is one of the few lesbians in the firehouse who won't be wearing her own necklace for a shot. Adora wolf whistles along with Mermista and Netossa as the photographer takes multiple shots, trying to get one that isn't too blurry. Even Catra can admit that she has a slight flush in her cheeks watching. The posed shots in front of backdrops didn't do much for her when it wasn't Adora, but Mara is *cut* and she is showing off her strength. As Catra watches Mara, she realizes that she is totally fucked for the group shot in the gym.

She isn't a part of it. It's four of them working out, both candid and posed. The photographer roams around, trying to find a good angle for a natural-looking shot. They are trying to mix in some shots from around the firehouse with the posed ones, and this gym shot fulfills the criteria while still being thirsty. Catra is *dying*. She is glad that Glimmer is in the shot just so she can't tease her about her reaction. Catra certainly isn't going to miss and opportunity to ogle Adora working out and flexing for the camera in a tight white tank top, sweat glistening on her biceps, but she is infinitely grateful that Adora can't turn away from the machine to see her fluster.

Glimmer's machine, however, is facing the gym entrance where Catra is lurking. When they finish, she grins as she walks past Catra, still leaned against the wall because she doesn't trust her tail not to lash yet if she removes the pressure pinning it still.

"Lesbian," Glimmer mutters. Catra's cheeks are red. She flips her off as she glances towards Adora and sees that she has finished toweling off her forehead and is watching the exchange with a bright, curious look in her eyes. Fuck. Catra desperately hopes that she isn't onto her. After all, they were all thirsting when Mara took her shot – or when Netossa did, for that matter, carrying a coiled hose over her shoulder that made all the muscles in her torso stand taut. Catra *is* a lesbian and no one in the firehouse is particularly bothered by when they appreciate each other, especially when they're trying to show off.

For all Adora knows, Catra was looking at Glimmer the whole time. She wasn't, but Catra might claim she was leering at her instead. As much as their weird flirtationship is a joke – Glimmer is happily married, after all – Catra would rather admit to it than risk her and Adora's relationship. The look in Adora's eyes almost reads as hope, but Catra can't take the risk. She can't try and then have Adora reject her. It would crush her and ruin their friendship.

She'll just keep quietly pining until Adora gives her a real sign, but given that they've known each other for over twenty years and Adora hasn't shown any signs of something other than brief attraction, she doesn't really have hope. They can't pursue anything based on attraction, not when Catra has been in love with Adora since she was eight. Something built on attraction won't last like Catra needs it to. She turns away from Adora before her heart can hurt too much and stalks back towards the garage. She needs to get her head on straight before the final shot.

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Those taking part in the shoot aren't on duty right now. For the final shot, they wait until a slow moment so they can get the entire firehouse gathered in front of the engine to take a photo for December. They decided they wanted something that wasn't risqué for the final month since people often have family visit over the holidays that they might not want to see that they own a pride firefighter calendar. They only get a few shots in before the alarm sounds to indicate a call has come in. The few snaps they took have to be enough as those on-duty rush off to answer it.

"I think that went well!" Adora declares cheerily as they change back into casual clothes in the locker room. Catra snorts as she pulls off the tight black tank top that she wore under her clothes for the final

shot and instead reaches for the ripped-up band t-shirt that she has been dragging around since senior year of high school.

"You're just saying that because you got to flex and show off," Catra accuses as she ruffles up her hair to fix it after the tight collar of the shirt flattened it down. She cut her hair when she started training to volunteer, partially because helmets were annoying with her mane and partially because she was nervous about it catching fire. With her hair's newer short length, she likes to keep it fluffy to make up for how little mass she has. She glances over her shoulder to find Adora sending her a performative pout.

Catra rolls her eyes and swats her tail in Adora's direction. Adora squawks and blushes a little when Catra's tail lashes against her ass. She wasn't really aiming for it, her tail is just at that height. Still, it threatens to make her blush as well, so she turns back to her locker to take a small breath. She swears that she can feel Glimmer's eyes on the back of her head. She knows she has been a useless lesbian today, but seriously, if Glimmer doesn't ease up then Adora is going to catch on to something.

"You should have seen how pouty she got when you left during her shoot and she couldn't show off to you anymore. Is she like that at the apartment too?" Glimmer comments gleefully. Well, there goes any hope of Catra's blush fading, but Adora has her head ducked and is dutifully avoiding eye contact, so maybe she won't notice. Catra huffs and slams her locker a little. Glimmer is just being mean now. She's rubbing things in Catra's face, but Catra is aware that Adora has always been a horrible show-off and it doesn't have anything to do with Catra. She just wanted more people to flex in front of and maybe to brag about her photos when they were back home too.

"She's been a show-off since we were five," Catra returns, burying her hands in her pockets and jerking her head to indicate for Adora to follow her. Glimmer snorts, probably amused by Catra's reaction. Adora is still blushing, but she hurries to follow after Catra as she stalks from the locker room. She is ready to go home and collapse

face first into her bed. Maybe shell even scream into her pillow while Adora is in the shower. t' s been a while.

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The calendar sells well. Catra's shot with Melog and the wider gym shot end up in all the preview promotional material for it. Catra is actually qite pleased with how the calendar turned out. She wasnt expecting it to look so empowering. They specifically talked about how they wanted the calendar to celebrate the strength of women when they were planning it, but she didnt think it would come across so well. There are only a few posed shots with backdrops in it, and even those often pictured them lifting or posing in a way to show off their muscles rather than just their tits or anything.

The calendar currently in their apartment is actually a titty calendar that Mermista bought Catra as a joke and then she hung up partially out of spite and partially to make Adora blush – and, alright, because she appreciates it too – but at the end of the day they are firefighters, not models, and that wasnt what they set out to make. They wanted a pride calendar, and they got it not only with the flag colors but with the sense of pride in the shots that were selected in the final edit.

"I like it," Catra tells Adora as they flip through the sample that was sent to the firehouse. They found a typo in the blurb on the back and want to shift the colors on a few pages, but other than that it's all ready to go. This sample of the calendar will be hanging up in one of the living spaces of the firehouse once the new year begins, but Catra isnt really surprised when she comes home from a shift at the Fright Zone to find a final version of the calendar unwrapped and already hanging up on their wall three months early.

"The picture of you and Melog is so cute, Idont mind looking at it for a while," Adora defends with a shrug when Catra asks her about it as

she fixes dinner . Catra is glad that she is staring down at the cutting board and Adora can't see the blush on her cheeks. "The report on the first week of orders came in today, by the way. It's going better than we hoped. As long as everything doesn't drop off after the launch week, we should meet our goal," Adora adds, unaffected by her own words.

Catra wants to linger on that first thought, but she lets Adora change the topic and start hopefully chatting about Catra getting a full-time offer in the new year. Catra, for the first time, realizes more time with Adora might be a bad thing, at least when it comes to keeping her feelings under wraps. She dices vegetables with her blush refusing to cool. She tries not to think about all that potential time alongside Adora, at work and in the locker room and in the gym and at home and in the bunk they share at the firehouse and- Well, trying not to think about it only conjures more images of it. Fuck.

Adora is oblivious, she comforts herself. Her happy chattering in the background as Catra cooks is evidence enough of that. It will be fine. It has to be.

Chapter End Notes

Will it though Catra uwu
Next chapter is a two-parter .

The Office Fire Part I

Chapter Notes

SCBA = Self-Contained Breathing Apparatus. AKA that big old face mask with oxygen tanks that firefighters wear on rescues where it's dangerous to breathe the air.
CW: peril to a child. There's an actual fire/rescue scene in this one, so just general warnings for that kind of thing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's good luck if Melog rubs against your leg before a call. It only counts if he does it after the alarm starts ringing and there's no actual *proof* that the calls after he rubs against your leg go better, but someone said it at some point and it just stuck. Adora is pretty sure that Entrapta made a spreadsheet about it at one point and she is sure that the data didn't prove out the superstition, but it still makes her smile when Melog rubs against the leg of her uniform pants as she pulls on her gear. She takes a second to tousle his ears before she runs for Emily and hops on the fire engine.

They are headed to a real fire. Sometimes they know, sometimes they don't. In the case of this call, multiple fire alarms went off in the same office complex, so the smoke – and fire – has spread enough to be a serious danger. They are headed towards a hard job and it feels good to have a small bit of assurance from Melog. He probably has no idea that he gives it to them when he rubs up against them like this – he's just following his cat instincts and marking them – but he is pretty empathetic, so maybe he does.

Adora has been on the scene of a lot of fires, but she thinks this might be the biggest she has ever seen a fire when they arrive. She sees the smoke from a distance as they drive up to the scene. They are all geared up already, but she doublechecks her equipment before they pull up so they can leap right off and get to work. She

thinks the office building must be old – both because it looks like it, and because it would explain the fire spreading so fast – but it's hard to tell with all the flames and smoke.

She is used to rescue scenes being chaotic. She is used to people yelling, or crying, or even running up and begging them to rescue someone or something in particular. She isnt surprised by the screaming as they pull up. What she is surprised by is the *children*.

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At first she jumps to the logical conclusion that there is daycare inside the office complex for employees, but no, that would be easy. Then they could be directed to where the children are. It's apparently *family day* for the company that rents out the majority of the building, meaning entire families have come for what was supposed to be a fun day off filled with family entertainment to show appreciation for the employees. Adora is willing to bet something brought in for the day's activities – either for entertainment or heating the food – started the fire.

The good news is that most of the families *are* gathered in one area. The radios of the different emergency workers on the scene are alight as they all coordinate to clear out the first two floors of the building, where most of the people are. The fire started on the second floor, but it traveled up way too quickly. There must be an elevator or a gap in construction or *something* that runs up the building and let the fire spread so fast, because their response time to the call was just a few minutes but smoke and flames have already overtaken the building.

Adora is helping get the families out from the second floor when she hears that some of the families are further up, having gone up to show their families' their workspaces. Her heart sinks when she

hears that. That means there could be children anywhere in the building. Children panic Adora. Adults are hard enough to handle when they are in shock or overcome by smoke. Children? Children might run toward the fire in pure panic. They might try to crawl under a table and stay there. You never know what is going to happen with them.

Adora has never been at a large fire like this with children in play. Smaller ones at shopping areas or personal homes, yes, and there have been plenty of false fire alarms at the school in their district, but she hasnt had to scan such a large area for kids before. When she goes back in, she is sent up to start scanning higher floors for more people. The building is already at risk of becoming dangerously unstable. They need to head up while they still can.

Adora's breathing is heavy in her mask as she climbs the stairs and listens to discussion about getting a cherry picker out to help rescue people from the higher floors. *The building was built in 0* comes over the radio. Yeah, that explains some things. At least the emergency stairwell has been renovated at some point. It would have been engulfed in flames by now if not. It means that they can use it to go up and rescue people, but she doesnt know how much it will help anyone inside when the flames are strong enough to make it difficult to even reach the stairs.

With every trip in and out of the building, Adora feels more tense. She feels like any of them could be her last before the building is judged too dangerous and they are all ordered to leave. She finds a couple on the fifth floor and is able to help them out, half carrying one and almost dragging the other, but when she gets back outside she can see Mara in a heated discussion. That can only mean one thing – theyre arguing about whether to call it.

Adora quickly drops the couple off with Starla and the other paramedics, turning so she can run back into the building. She knows there are more people inside and she wants to get everyone out that she can before the floors become completely unstable and

they have to resort to rescuing people through the windows with their ladders.

She spots Catra manning one of the hoses thanks to her distinctive helmet as she goes back in and she breathes a sigh of relief. Not that Catra cant handle the fire – she would be insulted by any such implication – but again, *children*. Catra usually isnt comfortable with kids on a good day, though she has gotten better since starting at the firehouse. Her not having to worry about it is a weight off Adora's shoulders that she didnt even know she was carrying.

She knows this will likely be her last sweep before Mara calls the building as too unstable for them to risk entering anymore, so she goes straight up to the higher floors that they would struggle to rescue people from even with their ladders. She will feel better if they sweep those floors. Given that the fire started low, people might have fled up. The elevator was also out of commission when they arrived, so if they didnt know where the stairs were or couldnt reach them, they could be trapped.

"*Entrapment on the top floor*,"comes over the radio. Adora' s heartrate spikes. That means someone up there called 9-1-1 to let them know that they couldnt reach help on their own. " *Adult magicat with bad burns. Child is missing. He thinks he' s in the northeast corner in a conference room*,"come more details, only spiking Adora's heartrate higher.

She climbs the steps, rising along with her pulse.

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Before Adora reaches the top floor , floor three collapses. As people rush to call-in and asses the situation, Mara's voice comes over the radio.

"The building is too unstable. Everyone get out," Mara orders. Adora's step doesn't falter. She has to listen to Mara in the field, but she is also almost there and she *knows* that their ladders won't be able to reach the magicats trapped on the top floor. She grabs her com.

"I just reached the top floor. I'm getting the entrapment and then I'll head down," she responds. As long as she *tells* Mara that she's doing it, she isn't really disobeying. Well, she won't be as long as Mara doesn't order her to leave immediately anyway. She listens with anticipation as she shoves open the door onto the floor with some difficulty and takes in the top floor. There are flames coming out of the elevator shaft – it has become clear that was what failed and acted as a funnel for the flames to shoot up the length of the building – but most of the floor is just filled with smoke.

"Alright-" she hears Mara start, but she doesn't wait for the sentence to finish before she calls out. It was confirmation that she could continue and that's enough for her. She needs to hurry. She has two people to find. To her surprise, she hears an instant call back. It isn't words, though. It's a pitiful cry that immediately tugs on her heart strings. It's the same sound that Catra made when she fell out of a tree when she was nine and broke her arm. Adora knows the far side of the building – the side where the elevator is – is where the adult magicat was trapped, but that was certainly a child, and it was off to the right. She goes for the kid first. They're closer and she knows they are definitely still alive.

"Help is on the way!" she calls back, trying to assure the kitten. She doesn't get another response as she hurries through the smoke-filled cubicles. "Get down on the floor! Give me another sound!" she calls. The kid could already be laying down, but if they aren't, they need to be with this much smoke. She doesn't get a call back right away, but after a moment she hears a whine, much quieter than the first call. It still helps her make her way to the rooms to the side of the cubicles.

"I'm right here. I need you to make sounds until I find you," she calls as she jogs along the aisle. The call came from one of these offices,

but if her target can keep making sounds, then that will be a much quicker way to find them than trying every door. She is really worried by the lack of words. They could be too young for it – magicats do tend to start talking later since their vocalizations let them communicate their needs with their parents even without words – but if they've gotten so separated from their father, then they're likely old enough to talk and are just *beyond* words. Best case scenario it's from stress and not an injury.

She gets a series of short, desperate sounding whimpers, growing closer as she moves. It's close *enough*. She starts peering through office windows and trying doors. The first one is a bust, as is the second, but when she yanks open the third, she nearly trips over a child, tucked under a chair just inside. Their little blonde tail sticks out from beneath it. The chair wouldn't protect them from the fire, but it probably made them feel safer to be enclosed. Hiding in the office was a good call, actually. There's less smoke in here, even if Adora never would have found them if they didn't call to her.

"Hey, I'm right here. You can come out now," Adora rushes, bending down and reaching for the chair to move it. To her surprise, the kid growls as the chair shifts. She sees small hands reach out and grab the legs, holding it over them like a shield. She could easily yank the chair away, but flames aren't spreading towards them despite how increasingly dangerous it is becoming to stay in the building, and she doesn't want to traumatize the kid.

"I need to get you out of here so I can go get your dad, okay? He called for help. He didn't know where you are," she tries instead. The small tail sticking out from under the chair twitches. A moment later, the small hands let go. Adora breathes a sigh of relief, lifting the plastic chair up and dropping it to the side. The child is small, a sandy-colored magicat curled up their side with their eyes screwed shut and only breathing shallowly. They must be elementary school age, far too young to be in a situation like this.

They hiss and twitch when Adora places a hand on them. They're clearly panicking but too drained to fight. They might have used all

they had calling out to her. She manages to get a hand on the back of their neck, grabbing it beneath their choppy hair and tugging at their scruff. They go predictably limp, allowing her to haul them up so she can carry them. Unfortunately, it means lifting them up into the dense smoke. The child gives a small whine but doesnt twitch or open their eyes as Adora tucks them into her arms and heads back for the stairwell.

"I've got a magicat kid on the top floor . Needs oxygen but doesnt look hurt. Taking them to the stairwell before I go back for the entrapment. No other signs of life," Adora says into her radio. Conversation has still been going on over it as she worked, but she was focused on the kid. The stairwell has fire doors and there is less smoke inside it then the rest of the building. She will give the kid oxygen for a few moments before going back. She knows that if she doesnt get him now , the father likely wont make it. The kid wouldnt have lasted this long without the shut door. There is a buzz of static, and then Mara's voice comes back to her.

"*Negative, take the kid and leave. We might suffer building collapse soon. We're moving back to a safe perimeter* ," Mara replies. Adora sucks in a breath. The kid doesnt even react in her arms. They are giving extremely shallow breaths. Their head is resting on Adora's shoulder and she cant see if their eyes are open, but she would bet they arent. They might be unconscious already . She does need to get them out, but shit, she doesnt want to leave them *fatherless*.

She hauls them to the staircase with her chest in turmoil. She is going to have to do CPR on them as soon as they're in the stairwell. She knows it goes against her training, but she is afraid they wont make it to the ground floor if she doesnt get them breathing first. She can assess their condition then. If she has any wiggle room… She has to go back. But she also cant leave all three of them at risk if the building does fail. Fuck.

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When she reaches the stairwell, sealing the doors shut behind her and laying the kid out on the ground, she realizes that they are barely breathing. Her heart beats wildly, but she doesn't panic – or at least, she doesn't *act* panicked. She doesn't have a spare mask, and certainly not one that would fit the kid, but they need air. She pulls off her helmet, and then her SCBA mask, holding it clumsily over the kid's face as she puts back on the helmet.

"*Adora, where are you?*" Mara snaps over the radio. Adora's blood is thrumming as she fumbles for her radio.

"CPR in the stairwell," she fires off before she drops her hands to their chest and starts compressions. The mask just provides air. It doesn't help them breathe and the kid seems to barely be doing it on their own. They need CPR to get them drawing in air after the smoke smothered them. The child still being able to cry out for her and the relative clarity of the office air versus the main area gave her hope that the kid wasn't that bad off, but *relatively* clear is far from smoke-free.

Now that she has her mask off, she doesn't know how the kid even *survived* in there. The stairwell's air is clearer than the office was and Adora is still breathing in a lot of smoke. Her racing pulse isn't helping, but she can't calm it down as the first two compressions do nothing. The kitten is so *small*. They're the entirely wrong colors, but the way they lay there with their fur a mess, tail limp, and ears turned down reminds her of Catra as a kid. Adora can't lose them. Taking off her mask is a pretty stupid thing to do, but she has to do it. They are trained in buddy breathing and sharing air, even if she shouldn't leave it off for long.

"*Get out of there, Adora. Now*," Mara orders, but her words only come to Adora distantly as the kid finally gives a hacking cough, followed by a series of smaller ones, and then begins to draw in air automatically. Shit. From the tone of Mara's voice, she is probably worried about the building coming down around them any second

now. Going back for the father isnt an option and the kid isnt ready for Adora to pull the mask away from them yet. She is going to have to carry them down the stairs while sharing air with them intermittently, which means that she wont have air herself for the whole time. She is trained in breathing techniqes to conserve air , but they are hard to engage in while carrying a kid and panicking.

This is going to be bad.

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She has to start pulling the mask away and taking breaths herself when they have only managed to get a floor down. As soon as she pulls the mask away from the kid, though, their breathing goes shallow. She hates to take it from them at all with how much smoke they have inhaled, but she knows that she has to prioritize keeping herself healthy enough to get to the paramedics or they will both collapse and all her efforts will be for nothing. Still, they only start being able to share the mask an even split of time once they have already reached the third floor. While the middle of it failed due to fire damage, the stairwell is well-built – and likely an addition – so it is still standing.

By the time Adora reaches it, however , her head is spinning and her lungs feel like she has inhaled ground glass. Unfortunately, passing the mask back and forth leaves her hands full and she cant answer her radio. She distantly thinks about how much she is going to get scolded for this as Mara comes back on the radio to demand her position again. She will get her answer soon when Adora emerges from the stairwell, but with the kid in her arms and the mask in her hand, she cant turn her radio on and any delay that leaves them in the smoke for longer is too dangerous to attempt.

"*Goddammit, Adora, I'm coming in after you*," Catra growls over the radio when several of Mara's calls have gone unanswered. Adora's heartrate spikes. She doesn't want Catra going into the obviously unstable building. Catra doesn't even have an SCBA as a volunteer firefighter who was supposed to stay *outside* and man the hoses. The only hope is that Adora is almost to the bottom anyway. She just needs to make it down the last two floors before anything else gives out – whether that means her or the building, which is groaning ominously.

There is arguing over her radio, but none of the voices are Catra or Mara. The EMS has been evacuating everyone to a safe distance and they don't want anyone else going in, or something. Adora doubts that Catra is listening. She manages to make it to the second floor when she hears a voice raise up from below.

"Adora?" Catra calls, her voice desperate. Adora lifts the mask to her own face, drawing in a breath so she has air.

"I'm coming!" she calls back, drawing in another breath before she turns the mask back down to the kid's face. She hears a loud crash from somewhere in the building above her. Something else giving out, probably. It occurs to her that there is no way this kid's father is getting rescued. She has to get them out, at least. Her heart lifts when she turns a corner on the stairs and sees the ear ridges of Catra's helmet as she climbs up to her.

"Adora!" Catra shouts, sounding both overjoyed and *panicked* as she sees Adora's bare face. Adora doesn't reply. She doesn't have the air for it. Shit. *Shit*. Everything is spinning. Salvation is so close, but with Catra right there, some part of her is assured and says that she doesn't have to keep pushing herself. Catra meets her halfway on the stairs and Adora doesn't hesitate to shove the kid into Catra's arms instead. As she fumbles with the mask, lifting it to her own face, she feels herself sway.

"Get them out," she manages. The edges of her vision are going black. Catra's expression through the protective lens over her face is

downright horrified. Adora doesnt have the air to say that she will be right behind them as she draws in the clear air from the SCBA. It doesnt feel like it' s enough. She needs the paramedics, but the kid needs them more. "Go!" she manages. Every half second that they spend staring at each other is another one that the kid is breathing in the smoke.

Catra's eyes are wide and fearful, but she turns and heads down the stairs. Adora leans against the railing heavily as she watches Catra go down the stairs with the kid in her arms. A second to breathe and recover and then shell follow . The kid will be safe at least.

Chapter End Notes

> Listen, it has to be a cliffhanger so Ican switch to Catra' s perspective, alright. Im not even being mean this time lol. Ive finished the draft of the rest of the fic so it wont be too long between updates.
> Ireally tried to google stuf f about the science of this one and different ways to treat smoke inhalation, so if anythings wrong, at this point Idont care LMAO

The Office Fire Part II

Chapter Notes

PASS = Personal Alert Safety System. It alerts others when a firefighter stops moving and helps in locating a firefighter in distress.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Need air for two when we get out. Adora's on the second floor of the stairwell. She was sharing air with a kid," Catra snaps into her radio as she reaches the first floor of the building. It took her that long to shift the kid over her shoulder and reach for her radio.

"Is Adora with you or still there?" Mara's voice snaps back immediately. Catra doesn't reply as she steps out of the stairwell's side doors. Mara can look and see for herself: *no*. Catra's heart is racing as she does her best to sprint across the wide perimeter that they have made around the building. The kid needs medical attention immediately. The second that she hands them off to the paramedics, though, she is going back for Adora. The building might collapse any minute for all they know, but Catra doesn't *give a shit*. If Adora is going to be trapped in the rubble of a building, Catra will be in there with her.

It would probably make things worse given that she doesn't have her own supply of oxygen, but Catra will follow Adora into anything, no matter how dangerous it is. She isn't going to fucking *leave* her in there and just hope that she is together enough to make it out. She seemed. Catra doesn't want to think about it. She crosses the large safety perimeter as quickly as she can. Starla runs forward to meet her along with Bow. Catra is grateful, quickly sliding the kid off her shoulder and handing them to Bow.

He's strong enough to carry them back on his own probably, but with help it definitely won't be an issue. Bow makes eye contact with her

and nods as he takes the kid. One glance at the kid tells Catra why Adora went to such lengths to save them – kids in general are her weak spot, but *this* kid it would have killed her to lose. The smart thing to do would have been to wait until they were out to perform CPR, but there's no guarantee that they would have made it long. There *still* isn't a guarantee.

"You can't go back in there!" Starla tries to call after her, but Catra has already turned back towards the building. Starla can't fucking *stop* her. She hears a few other people call behind her, but she isn't stopping for anyone except Adora herself, who still isn't coming over the radio to assure everybody that she will be out any moment. As long as Adora isn't here or talking, Catra is going back in after her. She knows now why Adora wasn't talking before – she just didn't have the *hands* to – but it has been far too long and she should have been right behind Catra.

Fuck, she didn't go *back* for someone, did she? She said she was on the top floor looking for the entrapment and Catra distinctly remembers that being an adult magicat. Adora wasn't in any shape to climb back up, but if she was bad *enough* then she might have thought that she was.

"Adora, are you there? Your PASS shows that you aren't moving," Mara demands. She has been tearing her hair out as Adora risked her goddamn life. Catra's heart plummets. The fact that Adora isn't going up is good, but being still might be *worse*.

"I'm going back for her," Catra responds when Adora doesn't immediately turn on her radio. Why the fuck isn't she *talking*? Catra does the closest thing to a sprint that you can in full gear, rushing through the side doors and back up the stairs despite the smoke in the air. She looks up as she climbs, trying to catch sight of Adora above. She can see her arm still leaned against the railing on the second floor, but she can't see anything else until she rounds the landing.

Adora is sitting on the steps – actually, more like laying – with her head titled back and helmet askew. She has her SCBA strapped back on – thank *fuck* – but her eyes are closed. Catra's heart plummets, the sight of Adora's face slack more terrifying than the ominous groan that the building gives at that moment. Catra rushes forward, reaching down and grabbing hold of Adora.

"Adora!" she yells, her voice cracking and desperate, but she feels like she is about to burst into tears. Adora is *heavy* in full gear, but as Catra does her level best to yank Adora to her feet, Adora's eyes blink open. Catra manages to thread an arm under Adora's and wrap one around her back, supporting her as she guides her to stumble down the stairs, but she can see the disorientation in Adora's eyes. Her breathing should be loud in the SCBA, but Catra only hears small, short draws.

"Adora, *breathe*, we're almost there," Catra instructs her. Adora isn't walking so much as stumbling as Catra drags her down the stairs and it takes all her strength to keep Adora moving forward without letting her fall and go tumbling down the stairs. She doesn't know if this is just a lack of oxygen causing disorientation, but Adora doesn't need a head injury on top of whatever is happening.

There's a crash above them. Not in the stairwell, but close. Catra's heartrate jumps. Every breath is choking, not enough oxygen coming in to meet her body's exertion, but she pushes forward until the doors are in front of them. There have been voices on her radio this entire time, but she hasn't had the space to pay much attention to them when they all sounded like they were telling her to stop. When she drags Adora forward out of the door, however, there is an instant chatter, including Mara's voice ordering the paramedics to prep.

Mara herself runs forward despite how she has been telling *everybody* to stay back and even tried to grab Catra to keep her from running in after Adora the first time. Now she rushes forward, reaching for Adora as soon as she gets close enough to help. Mara slides an arm under Adora on her other side, taking some of her weight. It makes stumbling forward more awkward, but Catra's lungs

stop screaming with the effort. It helps that the air is clearing as they limp across the empty expanse of the parking lot towards one of the ambulances behind the safety barrier.

Jewel and Tali rush forward to edge of the barriers, meeting them as they walk. Tali begins jogging backwards to stay in front of them as they move, reaching up and taking off Adora's helmet. She hands it off to Jewel, also hurrying alongside them, before she sets to removing Adora's SCBA. By the time that they reach the ambulance and its equipment, Tali is trying to free Adora of her restrictive uniform top so she can actually do something to help.

Catra doesn't fucking wait. Adora is still shallowly breathing. Catra yanks her own helmet off as they lower Adora down so she can be attended to, dropping it at her side without a care. The second that Adora is laid out, Catra ignores the paramedics and leans down to seal her lips over Adora's, breathing into her. The oxygen machine is being prepared in the background, Starla already rushing the oxygen mask down towards Adora's face, but Catra isn't letting Adora have even a few moments' delay. She breathes what she has into her, a small part of her noting *I never thought our first kiss would be like this*.

She is low on air herself, but she draws in more through her nose and gives Adora all that she gets once again. Adora's lips move beneath her in some kind of twitch as Catra reaches up for the oxygen mask blindly. When she feels it brush her hand, she takes hold of it and pulls back from Adora, instantly replacing her lips with the mask. Tali has managed to get her shirt open, but the uniform is only a secondary concern to Catra as she slides the straps of the mask around the back of Adora's head and sees her eyes are wide open and staring up.

She has to hope it's a good sign. She scrambles back to give the EMTs room to work, finally able to pull back now that Adora is hooked up to air. Everyone not attending to the kid swarms around Adora. Catra is trained, but it doesn't compare to what they know. She has to trust that they will help despite the panicked hammering

in her chest. She jolts as a hand lands on her shoulder, looking up to find Mara standing just behind her. Mara's eyes are fixed forward on the buzz around Adora, but she still takes a second to comfort Catra.

Catra is still breathless from the exertion. She carefully flops down, sitting on the pavement with her knees bent and her elbows resting on them. She tries to do breathing exercises, but they are hard when her heart is *hammering* for Adora. All she can do now is wait and hope.

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After what is probably only a minute or two but feels like a fucking eternity, Adora is aware enough to start giving hand signals. It only takes her a few seconds to communicate that she is uninjured but the smoke overwhelmed her. Catra's worry goes from abject terror to intense anxiety with that revelation. It seems that Adora will be okay, but Catra's heart isn't quite convinced yet. After a few minutes of supplying oxygen, it is determined that she will need continued observation, but that she isn't as bad off as some others who have already been sent off to the hospital with burns.

Adora tries to ask about the kid through her oxygen mask and is gently told not to talk by Bow. When Adora tries again, Tali snaps at her to shut the fuck up, something she can only get away with thanks to their acquaintance. Adora falls silent, but she doesn't seem happy about it. She gets her answer when they are both loaded into the same ambulance anyway. Both of them need medical attention. Catra manages to return to Adora's side right before they get her into the car, squeezing her hand gently and offering her a smile that she hopes is assuring. Adora blinks up at her, still seeming to be a bit hazy, even if the worst of the disorientation has passed.

"Stay quiet and do what everyone tells you. I'll meet you at the hospital as soon as I can," Catra promises her. Adora squeezes her hand back. Catra assures herself that Adora's grip doesn't *feel* weak at least. Catra releases her reluctantly, falling back to let the paramedics take Adora away. Catra wants Adora to see a doctor, but she doesn't want to leave her side either. She can't have both. They have work to do at this scene still – the fire isn't even *out* yet, they just had to pull back until they assessed the threat of building collapse – and Catra drives the fucking fire engine. She can't bail because Adora got hurt.

"She'll be okay," Mara assures her as Catra watches the ambulance pull away. Catra doesn't look away from the car until it is out of sight down the road. She knows that Adora will be okay in the end, but the next few hours at the hospital – probably the next few *days* – will be miserable. Catra wishes that she could be there to make it better. Dealing with all the hospital bullshit by yourself is hard. Not that Catra could do a lot given that she isn't legally family and can't make decisions for Adora, but it would make her feel better to be there alongside her.

"Come on, let's get to work," she mutters, reluctantly pulling her helmet back on. The sooner they deal with this fire, the sooner they can go back to the station and she can go visit Adora.

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The building doesn't totally give out, at least not while they're there. Catra is grateful when the fire is finally determined to be out and specialized search and rescue teams come in. The building still isn't believed to be stable – it will probably end up demolished after this – so they can't go traipsing in with their equipment alone. With the new crew's arrival, they can finally return to the station after spending hours on the scene. Tellingly, Mara takes the wheel for the drive

back. She has been working even harder than Cartra – after all, she is senior to her and in charge when they are on-scene – but Catra is rattled from the incident with Adora.

t must be obvious, because Glimmer disappears into Angella' s office when they get back while Catra takes a few minutes to pet Melog. She is just trying to center herself as she reads through the texts that Bow sent her letting her know where they brought Adora, but it gives Glimmer time to talk to her mom. When she re-emerges, she offers to drive Catra to the hospital. Catra should turn her down, not the least because Glimmer's shift isn't supposed to be over yet, but she looks down at Melog nuzzling into her hand and reminds herself that it's okay to accept help.

She used to view it as weakness – and she kind of still does – but she has been working on that over the last few years, mostly because Adora all but insisted on it. t' s easier to do sometimes than others, but today she just nods. Glimmer seems relieved. That relief is cut when Melog tries to get in the car to join them for the ride, but Catra eventually manages to close the car door without Melog jumping in as well. f she were going home, she would take them with her, but he wouldn't be allowed in the hospital and she isn't going to leave him out in the car.

Glimmer helps Catra get around once they reach the hospital. She has been in a lot of them to visit Bow at work – or pick him up after one of his transition procedures – and Catra has avoided being in one again since she broke her arm as a kid, so having help hunting down Adora's room is appreciated. They find Adora up on the third floor in her own small room. Adora is still hooked up to oxygen, but now it is just nose tubes, so she can talk again.

She looks tired, and maybe a bit bored, but she lights up when she sees who is walking in, smiling broadly. Catra runs forward without even thinking about it, hurrying to Adora's side. She goes to grab her hand before she realizes that she is hooked into machines and she shouldn't disturb her arm. Catra flexes her hands uselessly in the air for a second before forcing them to drop to her side.

"My other side," Adora croaks out. Her voice is quiet and rough, but she sounds fond. Catra doesn't hesitate to circle around to her other side, taking up her hand and squeezing it with a sense of relief. She doesn't like how hoarse Adora sounds, but at the same time it is a relief to hear Adora speak again. It is so like her to assure Catra when she is the one in the hospital.

"They're going to discharge me in two hours or something. I can't be around a fire for a few weeks and they stuck a tube down my throat for a while, but they got the crud out," Adora tells her. Yeah, her voice hasn't sounded this bad since she lost it when she had the flu a few years back, but she seems surprisingly chipper. Or maybe she is just relieved to have some entertainment now. Catra squeezes her hand, nodding to her.

"Don't talk too much. You should be resting as much as you can," Catra tells her. That was probably all of the important information, anyway. Adora pouts at her before giving a small cough and glancing between the two of them.

"Can you guys find out what happened to the kitten?" she asks, sounding both hopeful and worried. Catra glances back to make eye contact with Glimmer. Glimmer takes the hint, nodding and walking forward to place a hand indistinctly around Adora's knee under the covers. She squeezes her once before stepping back.

"I'll see if I can go hunt them down. I'm sure I can leverage a favor through Bow," she promises. Catra nods gratefully to her as Glimmer goes to leave the room, apparently assured enough by Adora being conscious and talking. When she leaves, Catra sets to rubbing small circular patterns into the back of Adora's hand with her thumb.

"I'm going to yell at you for being stupid and reckless and self-sacrificing later," Catra informs her, her voice tired. She's too exhausted to do it right now. Adora, oddly, smiles at that, looking up at Catra with wide eyes. Her face is so open and vulnerable looking, but Catra still can't read it. Maybe it's just the oxygen tubes and

equipment plugged into her making her look that way. Adora is usually a force of nature, but in this moment she seems *fragile*.

"You know why I had to do it," she breathes softly. Catra's heart clenches in her chest, her tail twitching behind her. She wills her body calm as she takes a deep breath.

"I do. But I can't lose you, Adora," she whispers back. It is far too vulnerable of a thing to say after hours of being run ragged by her emotions. Adora continues to stare up at her for several long seconds, her gaze searching.

"Did you kiss me?" she asks. Catra's entire world stops, her heart and breath and *thought processes* stuttering out. In an instant, the excuse of *it was just CPR* rises in her chest, but Catra just had her first real brush with losing Adora right before her eyes. It is something that she worries about sometimes knowing how dangerous their job can be, but it has never seemed like that worry might turn into reality before. Her heart starts beating again at ruthless pace, thrumming anxiety through her veins like electricity.

"It was CPR. Probably unnecessary, but I was just..." she trails off. Now should be the time to say *hopelessly in love with you and terrified*, but that is only if there is *ever* a time. Adora probably doesn't feel the same – although who knows, she clearly just risked her life to save a kid that looks like Catra – and she is currently stuck in a hospital bed. Catra is probably going to be taking care of her for the next few days. This would actually be a terrible time for things to get awkward between them. As always, Catra's old excuses and self-preservation habits kick in.

"CPR, huh? It sure felt like a kiss to me," Adora teases. Catra's gaze snaps up to lock eyes with Adora as her cheeks heat. To her surprise, despite Adora's confident tone, her gaze is unsure. Her eyes are searching by Catra's most conservative estimate and anxious or even *hopeful* by her most desperate one. Adora is trying to tease Catra like she always does, but it almost feels like she is

testing her – like maybe she knows and she is just waiting for Catra to say it.

Catra stares down at her with her cheeks red and her heart beating in her chest. It feels like she fucking *knows*. It feels like all that Catra wants to do is tell her despite all the years of convincing herself that is the worst thing that she could possibly do. The longer that Catra waits to reply, the more suspicious it gets. She stares down at Adora and, despite the fear in her chest, she can't help but think that if this had been it, she wouldn't have been able to stand losing Adora without ever telling her the truth.

"I don't know why I love you when you're such an asshole," Catra huffs, getting a half second to see horror begin blossoming on Adora's face before Catra leans down and kisses her for *real*. It's awkward with the tubes coming from Adora's nose, and Adora releases a muffled noise of surprise beneath her, but Catra holds it for several long seconds with her heart hammering in her chest. The kiss is chaste, but Catra's body is lighting up with excitement as well as anxiety. She has dreamed of this for years and it almost feels like a relief to finally do it, no matter what happens next.

"For the record, *that's* what it would have been like if I meant to kiss you," Catra tells her with false bravado when she pulls back. Anxiety flutters in her throat as Adora gapes up at her, seeming to be in total shock. Adora must not remember the CPR that Catra performed very well if she thinks it could be viewed as a kiss in any way. She doesn't think it compares to what she just did, though she's definitely biased. Adora is still just blinking up at her.

"Fuck, Adora, say *something*," Catra all but begs. Adora's mouth opens a bit more and then closes as she keeps staring at Catra. After a moment, she manages to swallow, licking her lips and trying again.

"Do you mean that? That you love me?" Adora asks. She sounds stunned still. Catra's heart races, but it's too late to say no, so she just nods. She is willing to pretend that Adora is still a bit out of it and

she would be a bit quicker on the uptake normally, but Catra kind of doubts it. Adora blows out a breath, seeming to need to *process* that revelation. Catra feels like she is three seconds from reaching a critical mass of stress and having her heart give out. At least they're already in a hospital.

"I love you too," Adora whispers back, her tone sounding almost wonderous and a smile tugging at her lips. Catra is the one gaping now, staring down at Adora. She feels like she is in shock. She never really expected Adora to *reciprocate*. She just had to say it after the earlier panic. Her heart is hammering in a very different way now. She feels like Adora must have it wrong – that she means platonic love and not *I've been fantasizing about our wedding for years*.

Catra takes a risk for the second time in as many seconds, leaning down a bit more slowly, watching Adora's expression brighten as she grows closer. Catra swallows and then she closes the remaining gap, kissing Adora more firmly this time. She isn't worried about being creepy this time – especially not when Adora kisses her back, tilting her chin up. Her breathing is heavy through the tubes and the oxygen machine is noisy, but Adora doesn't seem inclined to stop. Catra doesn't want to either – her body is singing *I'm kissing Adora, she loves me, I'm kissing Adora* – but she can't risk Adora's health.

She pulls back, breathing heavily herself, though that could just be the day catching up with her. Adora grins up at her almost dopily, looking so blissfully happy that Catra's heart feels like it flips over in her chest. If the words weren't enough to convince Catra that Adora feels the same, the pure joy written across Adora's face is. The emotions in Catra's chest also shine through Adora's eyes without even a thin attempt to veil them. Adora has always seemed like an open book, but clearly Catra has missed something important in her pages before.

As terrifying as most of this day has been, for once Catra's heart is racing with excitement. Not only is Adora okay, but the weight of the magnitude of her feelings for her best friend isn't weighing on her for the first time in years. For the first time *ever*, she can feel it and not

be afraid of how it will ruin them. Adora feels the same. t' s alright to love her.

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The kid's name turns out to be Finn. Their smoke inhalation is worse than Adora's, so they will be in the hospital for a while yet, but they seem to be doing okay now they are getting treatment. t is a relief to Adora. She is allowed to pop in and say hi to the kid after she is discharged. The kid cant say anything *back* with the breathing eqipment that they are attached to, but she pets their hair and promises that they will find out what happened to their dad as soon as they can. The situation at the scene was still unfolding the last time any of them got an update. None of them are optimistic, but they dont want to give Finn such a devastating news without confirmation.

Adora is exhausted, but she is still reluctant to leave the kid alone. Catra only manages to convince her to when they find out that the kid's grandmother is on her way to the hospital so that they know the kid wont be alone for too long. Glimmer drives them back to the station and Adora almost falls asleep in the backseat on the trip there. After they switch to their own car, she starts to drift off again despite the drive from the station to their apartment only being about twenty minutes long.

Catra has to help a sleepy Adora stumble up to the apartment while also dealing with Melog winding around their ankles. He wasnt about to let them leave the station without him again. He meows noisily at them as they make their way up, displeased with them both being too tired to give him attention. Catra is almost as dead on her feet as Adora is at this point though and she used up everything she had staying alert for the drive back. Melog will just have to wait until morning. Luckily, he qiets down once they get in the apartment.

Catra tries to help Adora into her bed, but Adora doesn't let go of her and takes them both down at once. Before Catra can try to free herself, Melog hops up on the bed and balls up in a loaf on her back. Catra huffs with as much drama as she can summon, but Melog doesn't move. Adora hums distantly, patting the back of Catra's head.

"Shh. Rest now," Adora mumbles. They aren't even under the sheets, but she doesn't seem to care. Honestly, neither does Catra. She's utterly exhausted after the day that they have had. She doesn't particularly want to get up to go to her own bed anyway. She probably should – she is sure there is some reason not to lay on Adora because it might impede her breathing – but why would she volunteer to sleep alone? She hates doing that.

Catra lets out a grumble that turns into a purr by the end and wriggles her head around until she finds a comfortable angle for it. Adora's hand on the back of her head flexes, cradling her close, and then goes limp as she settles in for sleep herself. Melog seems content for the moment as well. This might not be the best sleeping position, but Catra isn't moving for the world. She falls asleep with Adora breathing steadily beneath her, a quiet reassurance that everything is fine. Better than fine. Catra told Adora that she loves her and Adora said it *back*.

Today was bad, but they are still standing. Well, laying. Actually, laying in bed together is better than any other outcome Catra could have predicted. Adora hasn't managed to distract Catra from giving her a lecture on safety and taking dangerous risks with her life and health, but it can wait. This moment is far more important. Besides, Catra's fucking exhausted. She happily falls asleep in Adora's arms.

Chapter End Notes

> This is the end of the main fic, but there will be an epilogue next, and who knows, I might come back and add on another chapter if the firehouse calls to me again.

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

> Perspective is different for this one, bouncing back and forth between Catra and Adora for every scene (Catra, then Adora, then Catra, etc).
> **CW**: parental death mention, childbirth mention, death mention.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catraaaa," Adora whines from across the bedroom. Catra ignores her, continuing to fuss with her slicked-back short hair. Melog sits on the top of the dresser, slowly sweeping his tail back and forth while he watches Catra scrutinize herself in the small mirror that lives there. The dresser has been moved from its long-time "wall" status between their mattresses, now against the actual wall in the corner so their twin beds could be shoved together to make one giant bed. Not that they use all that space since Catra spends most nights sleeping directly on top of Adora, but Melog likes having so much room to curl up.

"Babe," Adora tries behind her. Catra can hear the pout in her voice. She snorts but she doesn't turn around. Adora gives up on words, just whining loudly now. Catra narrows her eyes as she straightens up.

"That's bad for your throat," she chastises, turning around to find Adora perking up at being acknowledged. Catra feels a flutter of affection in her chest at the way that Adora shines for her, smiling happily before she remembers that she is supposed to be sulking and she pouts again, sending Catra puppy eyes.

"I'll behave," she tries. Catra's lips twitch. The fact that she doesn't outright laugh is a miracle. Adora can't "behave" to save her life. Catra reaches down, cupping Adora's cheek with her hand. Adora instantly leans into it, her eyes fluttering for a moment before she

looks back up at Catra with a pleading look that could convince Catra to do almost anything, but not this.

"No. You're supposed to be resting. Besides, it's not my call. Angella isn't going to lift your ban from coming to the firehouse until you're cleared to work," Catra responds, even as she cups Adora's cheek. Everybody knows that Adora can't help but *help*. If she came by, even off-duty and supposedly taking it easy, she would eventually find something to do, and she isn't even supposed to be active right now so she doesn't breathe heavily and interrupt her healing. Adora's pout turns genuinely sad.

"But it's your first day! I want to be there. I'll just sit around and babysit Melog," Adora argues. Catra feels a frankly disgusting amount of affection for her girlfriend, but she responds by simply rolling her eyes, doing her best to ignore the way that her heart does small flips. She shifts her hand to place her thumb on Adora's lips, quietly shushing her. Adora blinks up at her with wide eyes, the tops of her cheeks flushing.

"Just because I'm getting paid now doesn't mean it's going to be any different. It's more like my thousandth day," Catra points out. This isn't really a big deal. Well, it's an enormous deal to *them*, but the most that is going to be special about today is her co-workers clapping her on the back and making jokes about her first day. It's more likely to be insufferable than exciting. It still feels like it represents something, but she doesn't think Adora will be missing much.

"It's boring staying home all day and I don't want to miss it. Please?" Adora asks. Looking at her big eyes, Catra almost breaks. Almost. She knows that if she *did* let Adora come, at worst she would start strenuous activity and at best she would manage to stay still but talk too much to compensate for her immobility. Catra is *maybe* fussing over Adora an undue amount as she recovers, but then again, maybe she isn't being careful enough. There's no way to know either way.

"Keeping Melog entertained on your own will be a full-time job. Think of it as a vacation. Most people would love to have a few weeks off work," Catra tells her , finally dropping her hand to pet the top of Melog's head goodbye. Adora isn't even dressed in real clothes, wearing boxers and a giant t-shirt that is almost too big to even call oversized but she bought anyway because it was super soft. She knew that Catra wasn't going to let her come or she would have actually tried to get ready. Still, she pouts up at Catra as she finally pulls away and starts heading for the bedroom door.

"Well, most people don't work with their *girlfriend* and get to spend more time with her when they're working too," Adora pouts, scrambling up from the bed to follow her out. Melog meows admonishingly as he is forced to leap out of her lap with the movement. Catra can't help but smile to herself as she gathers her keys and wallet. Adora comes plodding up behind her, wrapping her arms around her waist and burying her face in the side of Catra's neck. Catra, betraying herself, immediately begins to purr.

Adora *squeals* in response, burying her face in enough that she must be having trouble breathing, but she seems happy where she is. Adora has been extremely touchy ever since the confession in the hospital, though Catra certainly hasn't been complaining. Maybe she has been clingy too, but they have so many years of longing to make up for. The thought *I want to kiss her* will occur to Catra and then she will remember that she *can* and the next thing she knows they're making out. She has a feeling that Adora is going through a similar process considering how much she throws herself at Catra now.

The boredom is also a factor. Adora isn't allowed to exert herself, much less attend a fire scene, until she is all healed up from the damage to her airways. It left them down a man at the firehouse. Angella was able to do cursory interviews with all their volunteers and then bring the fact that none of them could pick up Adora's hours, plus the fact that they needed another full-time firefighter *anyway* , to her superiors in the city. Catra's hiring was finally greenlit. It still leaves them down a part-time volunteer and thus spread thin,

but they're better off than they were, and they can make it work until Adora is better now that Catra is able to give the firehouse her all.

Catra didn't even bother giving Hordak a two-weeks' notice at the mechanic shop. It isn't like he was going to give her a glowing referral in the future anyway and the fire station needs her right away. She only texted her coworkers a heads up because they didn't deserve to be blindsided by the workload when she didn't show up for her shift in two days. Today is Catra's first day being paid at the station, weeks earlier than they thought Angella would even be requesting for a new position to be created. Catra is excited about it – mostly she is excited to only be working one job now – but it won't be so different that Adora will be missing much.

"I'll be back in the morning," Catra promises Adora, reluctantly turning around in Adora's arms. As much as she loves having Adora wrapped around her – really she just likes it whenever Adora acts needy for her – she really does have to go to work. She doesn't want to be *late*. Adora pouts again, but she seems to perk up a little when she realizes how close Catra is, eagerly closing the gap between them to kiss her. Catra kisses her back, but the embrace is chaste. It's a goodbye kiss.

"Make sure Melog doesn't claw anything," she tells Adora when they part. Adora doesn't seem eager to let her go, pecking a kiss on her cheek instead, but after a moment she sighs and releases her. As much as Adora doesn't want to stay home, she knows that she can't fight Catra – especially not Angella *through* Catra. They only have one car that they share and Adora isn't getting in it with Catra.

"No promises. Especially not when it comes to *me*," Adora replies. Catra chuckles, sending a fond look to Melog standing in the doorway to the bedroom. As if on cue, he mews loudly, expressing his displeasure with the fact that no one is cuddling him in the bed right now.

"Don't be ridiculous. He won't hurt you. He loves you," Catra corrects as she finally pulls back and walks towards the door. She hesitates

as she opens it, still not used to *saying* things, but it is such a weight off her shoulders to let her feelings out her chest, even if it is terrifying. She looks over her shoulder and sends Adora a look that she is sure is disgustingly fond. "Just like I do," she adds, her voice soft. If she whispers it, it feels less sacrilegious to say after all those years of silence.

Adora's stunned but genuinely happy expression, joy slowly blossoming on it, is worth the vulnerability. Catra heads to work lighter than air, love thrumming in her heart.

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Adora eventually heals enough to be let back in the firehouse, even if she isn't allowed to go on fire calls for a while longer. She is going stir crazy by that point. She hasn't been locked in the apartment or anything, but her entire life has always been at work. She can only clean their entire apartment so many times while she waits for Catra to come home. It feels ironic that Catra starts at the firehouse only after Adora is forced to stop, but at least the situation is temporary and she is able to come back once she gets the all-clear from her doctor.

She will have to keep an eye on the health of her mouth, throat, and lungs maybe for the rest of her life, but aside from a staggeringly increased chance of throat cancer, she doesn't seem to have any long-term health damage from the incident. Angella makes her go through some safety training all over again due to her "reckless behavior" and she gets lectures from damn near everybody, but the point is made: her health can't take pulling a stunt like that again. She needs to stick to the playbook.

Adora can't say that she regrets it, though. Everybody asks her if she does and no one seems surprised by the answer, especially not

when Adora walks into the firehouse on the first day back from her enforced vacation hand-in-hand with Catra and then kisses her before they part ways in the garage. Catra had purposefully avoided telling their coworkers anything about the *personal* development that took place in the hospital, but she suspected that they were onto her anyway due to her "shift in demeanor." Adora tried to get details on what that shift was, but Catra refused to admit anything.

Adora was happy to keep it a "secret" until she could see the reaction in person. The reaction turns out to be Glimmer throwing her hands in the air and yelling *finally!* while Mermista swears at Perfuma that she owes her money. Angella already knew – she heavily hinted so when she met Catra privately to talk about hiring her and Catra quickly admitted it – but she agreed to keep the information quiet until Catra and Adora decided that they wanted to talk about it. She understood waiting until Adora was back at work, but they couldn't have lasted a second longer. They are ridiculously obvious now.

"Exciting call?" Adora asks, crowding Catra when she disembarks Emily after she drove it with a small crew to a car wreck call. Adora just wants a hug, but Glimmer pulls a face at Adora as she walks past her to take her gear off. Adora ignores her, pressing a kiss to Catra's shoulder before she happily rests her head there instead. She's just *excited*. She perks up every time she sees Catra and remembers that she can give her a greeting kiss, or hug, or just spill out that she loves her without their lives coming crashing down on their heads.

"Get a room!" Netossa heckles from over by the gear rack. Adora kisses Catra's neck in response. It isn't like Spinnerella and Netossa haven't made out in the bunk room before – probably worse, actually – but she and Catra are the new couple, so they're the hot target, especially since Adora is *already* a target after Glimmer asked her at dinner why she would be so reckless and Adora admitted in front of the crew that Finn looked like what she thought her and Catra's kid would look like.

Catra turned bright red and looked like she was torn between killing Adora and jumping her bones. They had a whispered discussion in the bunk room – actually, Catra was practically hissing – where Catra called her an enormous idiot while also marking up her neck. It ended with Catra squishing both of Adora's cheeks in her hands as she made burning eye contact and pointed out that they would never *get* to have that kid if Adora did something so reckless again.

Adora has always put her job before herself. You just have to in this line of work. Of all the lectures that she received after her hospitalization, she thinks that was the one that really got through to her. Suddenly it wasnt about herself: it was about Catra, and maybe, their future kid. Even thinking about having a kid with Catra makes her head spin. She would do *anything* for their kid and right now they are only theoretical. She has to take care of herself if she wants to get past it being a distant *maybe one day*.

The only other person who made progress getting through to her was Angella. Adora protested being sent through some of her training again – specifically the parts that cover the protocols she broke and oxygen conservation breathing techniques – but Angella just looked her flat in the eye and reminded her *you can't save anyone if you're dead or disabled*. It was a sobering thought, but Angella was right that she is no use dead. Catra's words, however, make Adora *want* to make sure she lives rather than just seeing it as her duty.

She has a feeling that Angella said it that way because she thought it was the only thing that could get through to her. She doesnt think anyone anticipated the Catra factor – Adora certainly didnt. She happily scatters kisses along the side of Catra's face as their crew makes fun of them in the background. Mermista says that they deserve to get mocked after all the pining they put the rest of the firehouse through – which, alright, might be fair, but even if it wasnt, the jokes are light-hearted. Not that Adora would care either way as long as she is getting to kiss Catra.

The biggest obstacle, honestly, is Melog, who has emerged from the trunk to twine between their ankles and meow loudly for attention. Catra chuckles as Adora pulls back to send him a pout. She used to be jealous of all the attention that he would get from Catra, wishing that *she* could be the one in Catra's arms getting scattered kisses. She got over it, and now Melog is experiencing a bit of what she went through. Adora loves him, but he can deal. She sticks her tongue out at him and then kisses Catra for good measure. Mermista wolf whistles, but Adora ignores her. She is finally getting to live her dream life. She is going to enjoy it whether her friends are watching or not.

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Finn's grandmother manages to reach out to the firehouse not long after Adora comes back to work. The crew didn't ever find out what exactly happened to their dad since he wasn't found until after they left the scene, but it wasn't a surprise to find out that he didn't make it. Finn was in bad shape when Adora found them. Somebody lasting hours longer in the same environment just wasn't possible. T alking to their grandmother was bittersweet, but they finally found out what happened from her.

Finn's dad was disabled and couldn't use the stairs when the fire alarm went off. He decided to take the elevator. Maybe he thought it was just a drill, maybe he didn't know that he could call emergency services and wait in the stairwell for them to come get him so he thought he had to take the chance. Either way, the elevator came along with a plume of fire. He got burned and Finn panicked, running and hiding in the office where Adora later found them. Eventually he must have figured that he could call for help because they got the call about the entrapment on the top floor, but it was just far too late for a safe rescue.

Finn's grandmother is human – Catra has to assume their dad was adopted or maybe Finn was – and Finn doesn't have a mom, though no one ever mentions why. It leaves Razz trying to raise a magicat kitten on her own, though, and Finn is certainly a *rambunctious* one. Razz reaches out because Finn wants to meet Adora again when they can actually talk and properly thank her, but then they walk in the room and see Catra.

"This is my girlfriend, Catra," was the simple introduction that Adora gave them, but Finn looks up at Catra with eyes just as wide and awestruck as the ones they turn on Adora, and Catra didn't even save their life. No, she was just born like they were. Finn latches onto her in an instant. They're seven, a bit too old to be clinging onto a stranger's leg and babbling questions, but Catra – shockingly, at least to herself – finds it kind of endearing. The rambling might just run in the family, actually, because Razz seems susceptible to it herself.

She is sweet, but Catra is somewhat concerned by how absentminded that she seems. She swears that is the only reason that she tells Finn that they can visit them again. It definitely didn't have anything to do with the way that their small claws pricked her leg as they clung on and flattened their ears upon Razz saying that they had to leave the firefighters to their work. Adora looks at Catra with practical hearts in her eyes as Catra cautiously pats the top of Finn's head and promises them that they will write back if Finn gets permission from their grandma to email them again.

"I don't think you'd be a sucker for kittens," Adora teases after Finn finally hugs them both tightly and lets their grandma take them back home. Catra glares at her and Adora's grin only grows wider. Catra... well, she *always* got why Adora risked so much for the kid, but now that she has properly met them, she definitely gets it more. They are precious and far too small to have been through what they have. Catra knows a thing or two about that. They both do.

"I don't think you'd be such an asshole, but here we are," Catra quips back, shouldering past Adora to head out towards the vehicle

garage. Technically they are on-duty, but unless they got an all-hands-on-deck call, they were supposed to be "engaging in community outreach" until Finn and their grandmother left. Catra was anticipating that meeting would be emotional given *everything* about the circumstances that lead up to it, but she wasn't expecting to ever see the kid again after this.

If anything, she thought the meeting would be closure for all three of them. Adora would get to see that Finn was alright, Catra would get to meet the person that Adora risked her neck for, and Finn... well, Catra has never had a parent really so she didn't truly understand how much Finn must be going through right now until they latched onto her, a total stranger, for comfort. They lost their only parent. They're an orphan just like Catra and Adora once were now, though at least they have some family left who is willing to care for them.

Kids have never been Catra's thing, but she can definitely handle this one visiting now and again or just emailing them. It will be fine. She ignores the grin on Adora's face.

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"I can't believe you both ended up pulling a stray out of a fire," Glimmer says, dryly. She doesn't actually sound surprised. It isn't like it is a *new* development, but this is the first time that Adora and Catra have done something so… *parenty* for Finn. Adora isn't certain what Razz does or if she's retired, but when it came time for career day, Finn asked that they come. Angella of course thought it was a great idea – *community outreach* is a phrase that has kind of become a joke over the last few months of Adora and Catra becoming weird adoptive aunts to Finn – so now they both have the same afternoon off in the middle of a multi-day shift.

"Mine's cuter," Catra comments, because she is a little shit, lifting Melog up as she says it and kissing him on the top of his head. Melog stares out with an expression that can only read as *help me*, but Catra puts him down after a few moments without any intervention. Not that Adora would have stopped her. She sticks her tongue out at Catra as she finishes putting her hair up. She would protest that Finn is adorable, but she knows that Catra loves the kid as much as she does. They aren't in a place in their life where they could have – or even really want – a kid of their own, but Finn needs some kind of parental figure that is more stable than their grandmother and both of them are more than happy to just babysit every now and again.

And to do things like this. It feels weird to walk into an elementary school again – Adora always wanted kids someday, but usually they take a few years to grow up before you get to the whole *school* thing and this isn't something that she expected to be doing in her late twenties – but it's worth the trip for the way that Finn lights up when they spot them. Finn runs up to them like they always do and promptly jumps into Adora's arms. It knocks the air out of her every time, but that has more to do with the momentum than the weight. Adora grins as she lifts them up and hugs them tight.

"Good day, squirt?" she asks, setting them down so Finn can throw their arms around Catra's hips and hug her from the ground. Finn doesn't usually try to use Catra like a jungle gym like they do with Adora despite Catra being more than strong enough for it. Finn's tail lashes behind them as they grin up to Adora. In an instant, they launch into a veritable tirade of everything they have done today. Catra tousles their ears and makes small verbal acknowledgements – *hm*s and chirrups and *how fun*s – as Finn ignores everything and everyone else.

Adora really likes the kid. If they hadn't had a grandmother to go to… well, Adora and Catra probably wouldn't have ever known that they needed a home and they can't afford to give a kid everything they

deserve right now, but Adora is happy to have them in her life like this.

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"She' s so small," Adora marvels. In her hands, somehow , the kitten looks even smaller than she did when the midwife first handed her to Catra. Catra has never felt this particular cocktail of emotions – and hormones – before and she just starts crying at the sight. She didnt even really cry during the labor pains – she didnt sob, at least, merely tearing up – but she sees Adora holding *their* kid and she just cant handle it. Adora, maybe predictably , panics.

"It' s okay, she's okay, look, she's right here!" Adora scrambles to assure her, carefully placing the small kitten back on her chest and wrapping Catra's arms back around her, making sure that the newborn baby is properly supported. Catra cradles her close, still crying uncontrollably. She cant help it. She' s happy. She's terrified. She's overwhelmed. You would think going through the entire process of getting medical help to get pregnant would mean it had sunk in that they're having a kid long ago, but it's dif ferent to *hold* her and see how very small she is.

Her ears are tiny and folded over, her tail only a small cone. She is too young to do much of *anything* and she seems to be sleeping soundly, but Catra swears that she grows calmer when Catra holds her. Maybe that's just projection. Not that Catra feels *calm* holding her new kitten, but she certainly feels an all-encompassing wave of love with her in her arms. It feels as good as it does overwhelming. Catra never wants to put her daughter down again for the rest of her life.

"I just- She' s *ours* and I love her ," is the best that Catra manages through tears and hiccupping sobs. On her chest, little baby Mara

gives the slightest stir, barely a twitch really, and then falls still again. Catra pets the top of her head with her thumb, cupping her with the rest of her hand. She's so *small*. When she manages to look up at Adora, she sees that her wife has tears in her eyes too. She already cried when she first held Mara and washed her off while Catra laid in the bed and just tried to recover , but clearly she can summon up more tears. Catra isn't really surprised – she was expecting them both to cry.

"Yeah, she is. She's going to be amazing," Adora whispers back. That doesn't help Catra to stop crying, but maybe she doesn't need to. Maybe she can just hold her new kitten, so small it seems like she can't possibly be ready for the world yet, and let herself feel.

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They lost Mara to a stress-induced heart attack almost two years after Catra started at the firehouse full time. It was devastating to them all, but Adora was the closest to her and it was really hard on her. When they found out that their baby was going to be a girl, there really wasn't even a question what they were going to name her . Well, Catra asked, but she didn't seem surprised by Adora's answer. The three-year anniversary was coming up. Adora wanted to honor Mara's memory, but she also wanted to hear the name Mara and be able to smile again. To think of all the happy moments with Mara *or* her future kid.

Mara the kitten is born three weeks early, but otherwise healthy. When she opens her eyes, they are just like Catra's. She has scruffy blonde hair, but Adora suspects it will darken over time given that her coat matches Catra's perfectly. She didn't really expect Mara to look that much like her. They wanted a kitten that was theirs and Catra was a bit uncomfortable with a sperm donor – she didn't want there to be someone out there who had, in theory, impregnated her, it just

felt *weird* for her – so they went with the stem cell method designed specifically for interspecies couples, but only parts of Adora's DNA ended up in the final mix, the rest filled in with magicat DNA to make the baby actually *viable*.

They wanted a kitten. Magicats tend to take care of their own, so there aren't a lot of magicat kids in the foster system – it's part of what made Catra's experience so hellish, no one really knowing how to handle her – so they decided to have one of their own. Holding Mara, Adora can't imagine having done anything different because it led to *her*. Adora isn't bothered by the idea of their kid being Catra's spitting image – after all, she loves her wife. Her blonde hair is adorable and makes her look a bit like she has a halo where it sticks up in tufts, but Adora won't care if it fades.

It turns out that the one person who *would* be bothered is Finn. They're twelve now, but they're still in Catra and Adora's life. Razz is showing signs of possible dementia. Part of the reason they waited five years to have a kid was that they weren't sure if they were going to be adopting Finn should Razz no longer be able to take care of them. It's still possible, but they've moved into an apartment that is just a five minute walk from Razz's house and Finn can bike over should they ever need help.

When Adora pulled them from the fire, she never expected that they would become a permanent fixture in her life, but she loves them. She loves being Aunt Adora to them, but it isn't quite the same as *mom*, so they eventually decided to have one of their own. They already have room in their life for Finn. If Finn ends up needing to move in with them, then they'll make it work. Their family is a patchwork, but it makes both Adora and Catra happy at the end of the day, so she wouldn't change a thing about it.

"She has to stay blonde! Then she looks like my little sister!" Finn pouts, patting the top of Mara's head. Mara is still only a few days old, but apparently Adora's suggestion that her hair might change is *offensive* in Finn's eyes. They won't look quite related anyway given Finn's sandy coat and dusty brown stripes, plus they don't share the

mismatched eyes that Catra and Mara have, but Adora doesnt correct them. She makes eye contact with Catra over Finn's head, sending her a fond look. t' s so cute that Finn wants Mara to be like their little sister.

Finn desperately wanted family when they first wandered into Adora and Catra's life. They never really knew their mother thanks to her and their father breaking up when Finn was only a few months old. Adora and Catra have spoken to her only once. Finn was an accident and she wasnt ready to start a family at the time, much less a family with her casual boyfriend. She had moved on and married by the time that Finn's father died, but she still didnt want to ever have kids. Adora likes to think that she would have stepped up if Razhadnt been there for Finn, but she supposes theyll never know and that's for the best.

Finn having Raz– someone who had always been in their life and always been *family* – was critical to them being able to handle their father's death, but it still left them without any real parental figure. Razwas their grandmother , and that's great, but not the same. They needed a grandmother *and* a parent figure. That's why they latched onto Catra and Adora the way they did. h some ways they are still trying to build something like a family even five years later, but they are generally a happy-go-lucky kid. t was a terrible thing to happen to a kid, but they've had the support to move on from it.

Adora is so grateful she could be a part of that support. Watching Catra give Finn instructions on how to pet Mara and sqish her cheeks without hurting her, she cant help but think *this is my family*. She loves them. Nothing in the world could be more important to her. She loves her jb – and if it werent for it, she never would have Finn as a part of her family – but as much as she loves going to work and marking a difference, she loves coming home to Catra more. That is going to be true even after Catra finishes her maternity leave and comes back to work because now Adora will be coming home to their little kitten.

And Finn, most likely. They come over after school a lot when Adora and Catra don't have shifts. Adora wouldn't have it any other way. Finn may be quite a bit older, but they are already eager to play with Mara. She will grow up with a guaranteed friend. Mara mews softly in Catra arms and Catra sends Adora a look as Finn's ears perk up and their tail swishes slowly with interest.

"What'd she say? Does she want something?" they ask. Adora places a hand on their shoulder as Catra chuckles and shifts Mara in her arms.

"She's hungry. You'll learn to recognize the sounds eventually," Catra tells Finn. Adora reaches out, smoothing Mara's tufty hair away from flopping on her forehead before she gently steers a reluctant Finn towards the door.

"Come on, Razz is going to get worried if you don't get home soon," she tells them. They walked straight over after the bus dropped them off from school, something Adora usually chastises them for, but she let them do it this time because Finn was coming to see Mara. Adora doesn't know how anyone in the world is just going about their business knowing someone so small and precious is right here. She knows that most people don't even know Mara exists, but it feels like everything in the world should have just *shifted* and all anyone will want to do is just look at Mara all day, petting her little head when it won't disturb her sleep.

She loves her kid a stupid amount. She has to be a rational adult. The world won't end if Adora leaves her for the ten minutes that it will take to walk Finn home and then walk back. Still, she sends one last glance back at Catra shifting Mara in her arms before she guides a reluctant and pouting Finn towards the door. Catra is looking down at Mara like she is the only thing in the world, purring to her softly. Her face is raw with the same emotions in Adora's chest.

"Aw, c'mon, Razz won't notice the time," Finn complains, twisting around to try to get one last look at Mara. Adora rolls her eyes, resorting to picking Finn up. Finn pouts up at her as she carries them

from the apartment. Finn might have a point – Raz often seems surprised by the passage of time – but if she *does* notice, she will worry, and she doesn't need that at her age.

"You can come back after you finish your homework *if* Raz says it's okay," Adora promises them. Finn whines at the mention of homework, going dramatically limp in Adora's arms. It doesn't phase Adora, even if it makes it a bit more difficult to juggle Finn as she opens the front door to carry Finn out. Finn is just dramatic like this.

"Homework is important," Adora reminds them as she heads down the hallway. Finn releases a growly huff, resolidifying their bones to curl around Adora's shoulder and bury their face in her neck as if to hide from the evils of middle school. Adora probably would have responded similarly at their age, but she tries to be a responsible example for her unofficially-adopted-kid-slash-nibling. Finn remains fussy in her arms as she carries them towards their grandmother's, but Adora isn't bothered.

She loves Finn. She's willing to put up with their fussing. She finds it cute, honestly. She doesn't mind carrying them through their little fit. She will be excited to go back to her apartment – maybe she already misses Mara and Catra – but microdosing on being away from her kitten is probably good for her. Besides, it has been a little while since she visited Raz. Finn eventually stops fussing, sweeping their tail up and draping it up over Adora's opposite shoulder as they settle in, more than happy to help Adora keep up with her strength training during her paternity leave.

They're clingy. Adora is more than used to it. She happily hums to them as she walks in the sunshine. They might have wandered into her life under bad circumstances, but she is grateful that they are a part of it now. She loves her family, as untraditional as it may be. It's *hers* – hers and Catra's – and that makes it perfect.

Chapter End Notes

Im disabled and this has been a safety PSA on what not to do (and what to do) if youre trapped on a high floor during a fire. You usually can actually use the elevator if the alarm just went off, but if youre uncomfortable with that or it isnt an option, then you can retreat to the fire exit stairwell and call for someone to come get you.

Honestly these last two scenes are ordinarily something Iwould leave for summarizing in the fic notes and not actually write, but Ididnt really want to do fic notes for this one, and Iwas just kind of feeling mushy, so Iwent fuck it, have a timeskip and a kitten. Catra and Adora semi-adopting Finn after rescuing them (and later naming their kitten after Mara) was in the AU plans from the very beginning, so it just felt wrong to leave it of f. f it' s not your thing, you can just skip the last two scenes Iguess lol. I wanted to write it.

Stem cell pregnancies for cis lesbian couples are a thing, so I made some bullshit up about how making it viable for different species would work.

Nibling: gender neutral form of nephew/niece.

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